

# Gates Scholarship

**Who do you aspire to be in the future? How are you setting yourself up to achieve that objective, and what steps do you need to take to ensure you reach your goal? (No more than 400 words)**

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized for four months in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's complete and undivided attention to make sure no such simple error occurred. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, I hope to create error-resistant technology that can not only help overwhelmed doctors but also allow them to focus on what requires their attention more. Every day, I see my family use technology that is critical to their survival. For example, when testing blood sugar which determines the amount of insulin people give themselves, if that technology had a bug, its effects could be truly fatal.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I aspire to become the "proof" for others that ideas, no matter how small, can become reality and flourish into something bigger than we could have imagined. To do this, I plan on developing smarter technology, especially for underresourced hospitals. While doing so, I hope to serve as the "first" publicly gay Egyptian to create an impact in the medical field and become the role model I needed when I was younger.

My Nystagmus project, which has taught me how to research, even if little is readily available, break through physical barriers to collaborate, and continuously improve from past iterations, has set me up to not only find and synthesize important details in our sea of digital information but also attempt new solutions no matter what research I'll do. I plan to use the concepts showcased in my program to create the first glasses to treat Nystagmus.

To reach my goal, I need to go beyond digital means. I will need to utilize the resources I have in college, including the experienced and innovative faculty, funding, and technology in order to create a device compared in complexity to the Apple Vision Pro.

Beyond Nystagmus, I hope to use those same steps to develop smarter, yet affordable technology for individuals with disabilities, create safeguards to prevent simple errors, and innovate new technology for incurable conditions, turning my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

**What connects you to your heritage/culture? What impact has this connection had on the person you are today and how you understand the world around you? (No more than 400 words)**

Creating countless Spotify Blends with my friends, I never reached a music similarity score higher than 90%. My music was not just Arabic or English; it was a combination of both

that no one else had. For years, I searched for someone with whom I could get a higher Blend score. While I was stuck in the 90s, my peers could easily get a score of up to 98%. These scores reflected the gap between my identity within both Egyptian and American cultures. My music, an integral part of my daily life, became too American for Egyptians and too Egyptian for Americans. I began overlooking my uniqueness to connect with others.

I lived in Egypt for the first seven years of my life. I grew up during the Egyptian Revolution of 2011. Around two years after the revolution ended, a song called “Boshret Kheir” (Good Omen) was released. The lyrics contained the names of the major cities in Egypt, talking about the “unity of the community” and the people’s new ability to “create laws with their voice.” The music video, released a year later, depicted many citizens holding up signs either stating the name of their city or different Arabic iterations of the word “Voice.” This single song essentially became the anthem for Egyptians worldwide. It connected us and gave us an immense hope that no other song had.

Attending college programs, I was outside of my normal community. It became rare to find anyone who spoke Arabic. I hadn’t known just how valuable this song and thus, my identity was until I felt like it was slipping away. Arabic music, alongside my deep appreciation for it, became a part of my Egyptian identity that I always had with me no matter where I went. It has become the most valuable connection to my culture, continuously grounding me within the values that I was raised with.

Since that moment, I have not once felt unlucky to have been born with complex identities. Without them, I wouldn’t have known about, let alone experience humanity’s biggest strengths. I saw people, including my father, fighting for justice, helping others even when it became a disadvantage for them, and uplifting their community even through their toughest battles. By connecting to and proudly showcasing countless Arabic songs and explaining their significance to others, I’ve learned to embrace my uniqueness rather than adjust for similarity.

**What academic topic sparks your intellectual curiosity? How have you gone above and beyond to learn as much as possible about this topic? (No more than 400 words)**

Technology, especially computer science, became my passion when I began creating entire homes, cities, and empires with my friends. Placing block after block, code ran my world. These blocks, simply data on a computer, like puzzle pieces, would fit together and become incredible works of art. The game became an integral part of my life. From modding the game to learning about what made Minecraft run, not only was I curious about the software that allowed me to play with my friends, I wanted to control it to create something new. I delved into the world of Java, Windows, and servers.

My dad, who worked with technology at that time, fixed his friend's old computer and gave it to me as a gift. Using this laptop to its full potential, I spent countless hours learning about port forwarding, custom domains, and the commands that made Minecraft servers run.

Starting the server with a simple world on Windows 10, I noticed an unusual amount of delay between the players' commands and their responses. I took a risk and ported my server over to an entirely new operating system: Windows Server 2016. While seemingly identical to Windows 10, allowed me to dedicate more power to the server, reduce lag, and thus create a more reliable server. However, this O.S. required a deeper understanding of the technology that ran it. Creating this server was not just "plug and play." For instance, port forwarding, which allowed users outside of my network to connect, required that I create a custom policy within Windows Security. I learned how to troubleshoot and fix problems and bugs along with entire server crashes. Seeing my server work seamlessly after a long period of troubleshooting, however, made it all worth it.

Creating my own Minecraft server reaffirmed my interest in technology, motivating me to take AP Computer Science courses and pursue a technological career.. With the knowledge I gained from these courses leading to creations such as my Nystagmus project, I developed a passion for breaking barriers. I plan to continue learning about the foundations of the technology we use, transform my imagination into reality, and utilize them to create an impact on our daily lives.

**What does leadership mean to you? Describe how you have exemplified leadership via one, or several, of your high school extracurricular pursuits. (No more than 400 words)**

"Why do your eyes shake like that?"

No matter who I was talking to, I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. The conversation would completely shift to something I had no control over.

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there have been no efforts to find one. Even though me and my sister both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing even more difficulty in finding a cure.

Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. I found individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook. When they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it was still, thus improving their vision. With these results, I was able to improve twelve individuals' vision, utilizing the concepts shown in the program for my future goal of creating the first glasses to treat Nystagmus

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. I saw

families, ones that mirrored mine, have hope for their loved ones. Not only did my project impact its participants, but it also created a sense of acknowledgment for those who knew about Nystagmus. Experiences like these drive me to advance research on rare conditions, utilize the resources I'll have in college to continue enhancing medical technology, and ensure everyone receives the recognition and care they deserve.

# Governing Board

"Why I wish to be considered for a scholarship toward my future education" (Must be 2,500 characters or less.)

"Why do your eyes shake like that?"

No matter who I was talking to, I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes.

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there have been no efforts to find one. Even though my sister and I both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing even more difficulty in finding a cure.

Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. I found individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook. When they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it were still, thus improving their vision. With these results, I was able to improve the vision of my twelve participants. Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. I saw families, ones that mirrored mine, have hope for their loved ones. I plan to utilize the concepts shown in my program towards my future goal of creating the first glasses to treat Nystagmus.

Beyond Nystagmus, I plan to use those same ambitions to develop smarter, yet affordable technology for individuals with disabilities, create safeguards to prevent simple errors, and innovate new technology for incurable conditions. In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on, causing an extremely preventable death. Experiences like these also drive me to create technology to make medicine safer. I hope to use this scholarship to work towards this goal, utilizing the resources I'll have in college to continue enhancing medical technology and ensure everyone receives the recognition and care they deserve. The Hearthstone Housing Foundation, especially with my parents' inability to financially support my higher education, will help relieve a significant burden. With this scholarship, I can focus less on financial strain and more on turning my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on, causing an extremely preventable death. Experiences like these also drive me to create technology to make medicine safer.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, my goal is to research and create medical technology that focuses on patient safety and can better provide for their needs. To me, Biomedical Engineering is not just a major but a pathway to finding cutting-edge solutions to problems that are universal to humanity. I hope to use this scholarship to work towards this goal,

utilizing the resources I'll have in college to continue enhancing medical technology, and ensure everyone receives the recognition and care they deserve.

QB main app

***We are interested in learning more about you and the context in which you have grown up, formed your aspirations, and accomplished your academic successes. Please describe how the most influential factors and challenges in your life have shaped you into the person you are today. (800 words)***

I put my phone under my pillow every night.

I used to leave it charging on my desk until I was jolted awake at 4 A.M. with my phone unlocked in my mother's hand, my heart now racing. At fourteen, my faith in my parents shattered when their one promise, checking my phone only with my permission, was now broken. I started putting my phone under my pillow every night, hoping the weight of my head would be enough to protect my privacy. Nights like these became stagnant, I couldn't keep critical conversations, maintain long-term connections with my peers, or grow during the transitional years of my life.

Two years prior, I came out as gay to my traditional Christian Egyptian parents. As a result, they took every step to control my life to ensure their child would "return to God." They checked my phone daily, opening every app, photo, and text while also revoking my access to social media. It wasn't until my parents threatened to move me to a religious school or a more conservative state that I finally accepted their harsh reality: they'd rather their son forfeit his future than be gay. I had a path that paved the way for success: I had a path that paved the way for success: friends who supported my accomplishments, opportunities I thrived in, and teachers who became my chosen family. None of that mattered to my parents. My "home" became a prison. I couldn't sacrifice the countless opportunities at my small, yet high-achieving, school. I had to prioritize my future over aspects of my life I couldn't yet control. To ensure my circumstances wouldn't worsen, I had to lie; I told my parents I was confused and had repented.

Although I was allowed to use social media again and still go to this school, my parents did not stop checking my phone. For the next three years, I erased every trace of my sexuality. I asked my friends to unsend entire conversations every time we talked about love, fearing my parents would discover the messages, and rip away the opportunities and relationships I had.

I thought my life would never stop persisting in these conditions. It wasn't until sophomore year that my mother traveled to Egypt to care for my ill grandmother. For four months, the constant fear of losing everything I had was alleviated. When she returned, I wanted her to envision what I remembered every day she was home. Instead of forcing myself back into hiding, I took a risk and showcased my perspective to her.

"Who you are, your face, your eyes, it all changes when you hold my phone." I cried to my mother, tears streaming down my face. She finally agreed to stop checking my phone under the condition that I didn't "turn against God."

To maintain the newfound peace I had, I retold everyone I was straight, continued deleting messages, and did whatever it took to protect my privacy. These actions constantly damaged my closest relationships and my sense of self. I knew my hiding could not continue for long. Gradually, I stopped deleting messages, took more risks, and developed my own beliefs and identity.

As life became more manageable, I yearned for a community that accepted the person I became. Searching outside of my comfort zone to find it, I attended summer programs; I connected with passionate, like-minded students who had their own stories, experiences, and dreams.

For the first time, I continuously put myself out there, fearing next to nothing. I gained priceless, lifelong connections with others. My dream of being understood and supported for who I was became a

reality; I was truly not alone. No longer was I fighting to create a false narrative of myself; I began to fight to become a person I was comfortable being. My sexuality was no longer a topic of gossip being spread as if I had committed a crime. Rather, it simply became just one of the complex identities I had. This period, when I was unapologetically myself, became a preview of my future college life.

From going outside of my comfort zone, embracing challenging educational opportunities, to becoming unafraid to connect with people I've never interacted with before, my perseverance through adversity has motivated me to persistently take risks in both my academic and social life. My college life will give me the space, community, and independence I've searched for—a place where my head is no longer simply a deadweight used to protect my privacy—and I can be myself without any fear.

Other Questions:

***So that we can learn more about you, please tell us: what question would you want us to ask you? Enter only the question itself.***

How have you connected your Egyptian culture with the culture you've developed in the United States?

***How and why do you think this question can be a good application question for you? (75 Words)***

No applicant should be looked at simply by their scores, accomplishments, or extracurriculars. Understanding someone's background, culture, and the connections they make with their identity is crucial to fully assess an individual's capabilities. Identity can be found in one's own culture but also in the ability to connect with the other cultures with which they interact. This question allows me to express the complexities of who I am in a more personal way.

***ANSWER THE QUESTION!! (200 Words)***

Creating countless Spotify Blends with my peers, I never reached a music similarity score higher than 90%. My music was not just Arabic or English; it was a combination of both that no one else had. These scores reflected the gap I felt between my identity within both Egyptian and American cultures. My music, an integral part of my daily life, became too American for Egyptians and too Egyptian for Americans.

I searched for someone with whom I could get a higher score. While I was stuck in the 90s, my peers could easily get a Blend score of up to 98%. I overlooked my uniqueness to connect with others.

Driving my friend to the mall, I blasted Arabic and English bops. On the way there, he said, "You have the best music taste out of all my friends. I like the diversity of it."

Since that moment, instead of perceiving my musical preferences as a weakness, I began to recognize them as an indication of my ability to embrace the uniqueness of each culture I've been exposed to. By proudly choosing the music during every car ride, I've learned to embrace my uniqueness rather than adjust for similarity.

***Tell us about a time you learned something new and were excited to uncover more information about that topic. (400 Words)***

I create entire homes, cities, and empires with my friends. Placing block after block, I loved spending time after school playing Minecraft. These blocks, like puzzle pieces, would fit together and become incredible works of art. The game became an integral part of my life. From modding the game to learning about what made Minecraft run, not only did I want to learn about the software that allowed me to play with my friends, I wanted to control it.

I delved into the realm of Minecraft servers. My father, who worked with technology at that time, fixed his friend's old computer and gave it to me as a gift.. Using this laptop to its full potential, I spent countless hours learning about port forwarding, custom domains, and the commands that made Minecraft servers run.

Starting the server with a simple world on Windows 10, I noticed an unusual amount of delay between the players' commands and their responses. I took a risk and ported my server over to an entirely new operating system: Windows Server 2016. This O.S., while seemingly identical to Windows 10, allowed me to dedicate more power to the server, reduce lag, and thus create a more reliable server. However, this O.S. required a deeper understanding of the technology that ran it. For instance, port forwarding, which allowed users outside of my network to connect, required that I create a custom policy within Windows Security.

After creating the foundations for the server, I began adding multiple worlds, custom plugins, and even a custom domain. While I only had a few people on my server, we created a world of memories together.

Creating this server was not just "plug and play.". I learned how to troubleshoot and fix problems and bugs along with entire server crashes. Seeing my server work seamlessly after a long period of troubleshooting, however, made it all worth it.

Creating my own Minecraft server taught me the ability to start from scratch, even without knowing the outcome. It became my catalyst to take AP Computer Science courses. With the knowledge I gained from these courses leading to creations such as my Nystagmus project, I developed a passion for breaking barriers. I plan to continue learning about the

foundations of the technology we use, transform my imagination into reality, and utilize them to create an impact on our daily lives.

*What is your favorite subject to study, and why? (35 words)*

Biology is in every part of our lives. From the leaves changing color, DNA replicating to zygotes growing into entire organisms, the study of life is beautiful in both its simplicity and complexity.

*What are your favorite books and/or movies? (35 words)*

*Where the Crawdads Sing*, incorporating mystery, law, biology, and social injustice truly made it one of the most influential books in my life. I strive to be as courageous, passionate, and brave as Kya.

*What is your favorite source of inspiration? (35 words)*

Taylor Swift, through her music, actions, determination, and perseverance, has inspired me since my childhood. Her ability to evolve, as seen through her music, motivates me to grow and change as well.

*How do you spend a typical weekend? (35 words)*

I volunteer at my local hospital, study, go on drives with my friends, and watch my favorite show, Grey's Anatomy. Driving around my city and visiting new places became a refreshing routine.

*What compliment are you most proud of receiving and who gave it to you? (35 words)*

"You look like Harry Potter." I take pride in a comparison, given by both peers and adults, to a character known as "The Boy Who Lived," whose scars emphasized his resilience through the toughest challenges.

*After a challenging experience, how do you rejuvenate? (35 words)*

Driving with friends, listening to music, or even simply hanging out has become my support system, inspiration, and motivation through challenging experiences and hardships.

*What would you contribute to your future college campus community? (35 words) -*

I plan to showcase the diverse perspectives I've been exposed to, foster a more inclusive community, celebrate my Egyptian culture, and serve as a beacon of motivation and support for others.

QuestBridge

## **Questbridge Ranking**

1. Penn
2. MIT

**MIT** *What field of study appeals to you the most right now? (Note: Applicants select from a recdrop-down list.) Tell us more about why this field of study at MIT appeals to you. (100 Words)*

If his oxygen tank had been turned on, my mom's coworker could have recovered. When my grandma was hospitalized, she required my mom's undivided attention to ensure no such errors occurred.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I plan on developing error-resistant technology, especially for underfunded hospitals. At MIT, I'm excited to take courses like "Principles and Practice of Assistive Technology," where I can develop technology for individuals with disabilities, and present at the BE Career Expo to turn my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

Despite my desire to take AP Physics, I had to choose between AP Chemistry or AP Physics as they were scheduled during the same period.

## **Penn**

*Write a short thank-you note to someone you have not yet thanked and would like to acknowledge. (We encourage you to share this note with that person, if possible, and reflect on the experience! ) (150-200 words)*

If it wasn't for you, my closest friend, I would not have understood the importance of community. Not only were you with me from the moment I discovered my sexuality to the day I came out to an entire group, you became an inspiration and I cannot imagine where I would be without your support. I can't forget our last year of school together when you signed my yearbook, almost six years after our friendship began, writing "I'll always be there for you and I know you'll be there for me."

Even though we don't speak as much since you're off to college, our checkups, the FaceTimes filled with laughter, stories, and the inside jokes we share mean everything to me. They are a constant reminder that no matter what phase of life I'm in, I'll always make it out a better man. Because of you, I became the person people go to for both comforts and laughs. I hope to have supported others as much as you supported me. In all of my relationships, I strive to recreate the safe space that you gave me.

Thank you, Carolina.

*How will you explore community at Penn? Consider how Penn will help shape your perspective and identity, and how your identity and perspective will help shape Penn. (150-200 words)*

After high school, I will have come out to my parents. In college, I'll no longer have contact with my biological family; **I hope to find my chosen and accepting family at Penn.**

When I emailed Penn Admissions about summer/winter housing, explaining my situation, they said something that has not since left my mind.

"Quakers take care of each other."

At Penn, I plan to not only find the community I'll be a part of throughout my undergraduate life but also continuously uphold this standard. My identity as an Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so is Penn's vibrant, diverse, and accepting community. I know I can celebrate every part of my identity at Penn. I connected with some of my closest friends from PEEP. When I shared my story for the first time in our group chat, I was shocked by how many people related to my experiences. I'll continue sharing my story and ensuring that anyone going through similar hardships knows they are not alone.

I will prove that Quakers do truly take care of each other through both hardships and accomplishments.

*Describe a problem that you solved that showed leadership and creativity. (250 words maximum)*

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

No matter who I was talking to or what I was talking about, I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. The conversation would completely shift to something I had no control over.

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there have been no efforts to find one.

Even though me and my sister both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing the difficulty of finding a cure. Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. Finding individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook, when they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it was still, thus improving their vision.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. This experience drives me to advance research on rare conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receive the recognition and care they deserve.

## *Penn M & T*

Explain how you will use the M&T program to explore your interest in business, engineering, and the intersection of the two. (400-650 words)

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on. This simple error caused an extremely preventable death. When my grandma was also hospitalized, she required my mother's undivided attention to ensure no such errors occurred. Every day, I see my family use technology that is critical to their survival. Testing their blood pressure and sugar which determines the amount of insulin they give themselves, if that technology had a simple bug, error, or mistake, its effects could be truly fatal.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. Penn's Center for Health, Devices, and Technology will equip me with the tools I need to create impactful, life-dependent technology that focuses on patient safety and accessibility while fulfilling every person's unique needs. I'll take my concepts, such as my Nystagmus project, to new heights. Joining the year-long Health-Tech Accelerator program, I'd build on my previous research with the resources, funding, and guidance I'll have to create the first glasses that can treat Nystagmus using oscillation.

While technology can assist, it can unfortunately never truly cure some conditions. At the Center for Precision Engineering, I'll work under the Biomimicry Research Thrust to research biological treatments and cures for conditions beyond just Nystagmus, giving hope to others who wouldn't expect their rare conditions to be worked on in laboratories. I'll apply for Penn's Summer Undergraduate Internship Program to learn what it fully takes to research, using those skills to eventually start my own.

To be in a place where innovation can be truly impactful, especially in a society driven by economics, I need to supplement my engineering skills with critical entrepreneurship, management, and marketing skills. At the Mack Institute For Innovation Management, I plan to connect with leaders who have succeeded in their own fields, learn from their priceless experiences and insights, and can therefore learn what it takes to turn an idea into a successful venture. Through Wharton's Venture Lab, I'll apply for the Wharton Innovation Fund, using this resource to continue developing my research and showcase it in the Venture Lab Entrepreneurship Expo. Not only would I be given a platform to showcase my ideas with tremendous support, guidance, and connections, but I'd also be inspired by the innovation of other passionate individuals using the same platform. Through the Startup Internship Award, by working at other impactful startups, I'll spend my time gaining valuable leadership, collaboration, and marketing skills outside of my own innovations.

In Penn's M&T program, courses such as MGMT 2370 (Management of Technology) will allow me to explore the intersection between engineering and entrepreneurship by learning how technological businesses both succeed and fail. OIDD 2380 (M&T Global Exploration), where my class will go abroad, will expose me to international, diverse, and thriving cultures of

innovation. Utilizing the skills, experiences, and knowledge I'll gain in these courses, I can not only learn how to strategically create my products but also showcase them.

The M&T journey, taken with an extremely close-knit community of diverse and driven students, creates an unmatched environment combined with an education that will stick with me for a lifetime. Studying engineering and business, especially through Penn's M&T program, will not only provide me with the skills, knowledge, and network I need to successfully innovate, pitch my ideas, and market, but also allow me to create both functional and marketable products.

With the education, community, and skills I'll gain in Penn's M&T Program, I can truly be the change I wish to see. Both throughout and after this unparalleled program, I will be able to turn my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

With Penn's various initiatives to utilize engineering for medical purposes, I will work on research in Biomechanics. Under the works of Professor Paulo Arratia, who, with a simple mutation in a swimming worm was able to turn it into an effective drug treatment, I know that I will be surrounded by a community of individuals who have and are ready to continuously break through barriers.

Outside of my passion for creating medical technology, I will continue developing my robotics skills through the General Robotics, Automation, Sensing and Perception (GRASP) Lab. As captain of my FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics team, I cannot wait to immerse myself in an environment where every day a newer, greater device is developed and used. I plan to also be that person driving change within that lab, showcasing a new device or a "cool prototype."

The main purpose of engineering is to problem-solve. Problems are the driving force of innovation, especially in engineering. At Penn's Institute for Computational Science (PICS), from helping a single individual improve their daily life to solving climate change, I would be proud to use my Penn Engineering skills in the real world.



## Stanford:

What is the most significant challenge that society faces today? (50 Words)

The drastic digitization of our lives has allowed society to find another way to misperceive, dehumanize, and divide.

Technology should be a tool to help us connect more in real life rather than replace it.

Changing the role of technology can allow innovation without the cost of human connections.

How did you spend your last two summers? (50 words)

Before I got my license, in the summer, I biked every day to the mall and gym.

This summer, I learned how to write in Arabic and how our brain works through college courses, attended a pre-med program, and worked at my first official job.

What historical movement or event do you wish you could have witnessed?

I'm interested in the ways small, yet compounding actions and beliefs led to the society we live in today.

From the Roe V. Wade decision in 1973 to its overturning in 2022, I wish to witness the period in which conservative beliefs continuously gained momentum, starting with the Reagan era.

Briefly elaborate on one of your extracurriculars, a job you held, or responsibilities you have for your family (50 Words)

Throughout my sophomore year, while my mother went to Egypt to take care of my ill grandmother, I was responsible for my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma.

This experience taught me time management, resilience, and perseverance, qualities that will benefit my future endeavors both throughout college and my career.

List 5 things that are important to you

I love my Arabic culture and music.

My Coptic, Egyptian identity shaped how I was raised and thus my core values.

Writing is an immense part of my life.

My community resembles who I am continuously inspired to be.

I aim to be a safe space for others.

Virtually all of Stanford's undergraduates live on campus. Write a note to your future roommate that reveals something about you or that will help your roommate — and us — get to know you better. (100 to 250 words)\*

Those moments where you're in a sleepover with your friends, huddled in a circle, eager to continue your story after everyone finishes reacting to what you said; that's the atmosphere I aspire to create. Senior year has been the most eventful year of my life; you'll hear many stories with plot twists that you couldn't predict.

I am a night owl. Something about studying when everything else stops allows me to focus like no other time. During those sessions, you will definitely hear Taylor Swift blasting through my earphones; if you're not currently a Swiftie, you will be!

I've gone through so many career changes I've lost count of them. You'll see me develop various passions in almost every field; from the remarkable connections and predictions history makes to our present, dystopian novels depicting current events decades into the future, one zygote developing into an extremely complex organism, and attempts to comprehend the entire universe itself, I hope I can at least motivate you to explore fields you've never considered before, and maybe even take a class outside of our majors together.

When I participated in college programs, I rarely stayed in my dorm. I plan to pack my day with opportunities that I can fully take advantage of at Stanford; there's no reason not to. While I might sometimes be exhausted, I wouldn't do anything less.

Get ready, roomie! I hope to turn our dorm into a shared, safe space for inspiration, motivation, and collaboration.

Please describe what aspects of your life experiences, interests and character would help you make a distinctive contribution as an undergraduate to Stanford University.\* (250 Words)

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

This was the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. The conversation would completely shift to something I had no control over.

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there have been no efforts to find one.

Even though me and my sister both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing the difficulty of finding a cure. Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. Finding individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook, when they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it was still, thus improving their vision.

Presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, shocked by this recognition— a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair.

Driven by experiences like these, at Stanford, I will utilize its opportunities, such as the Camarillo Lab, to advance research on similar “rare” conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receives the recognition and care they deserve.

BOFA

**\*Please list the significant community and volunteer activities in which you participated over the last two years. Include your leadership role and the estimated number of hours you participated in each activity.**

Example:

Habitat for Humanity - Volunteer - 7 hours total (1 day event)  
Church Youth Group - President - 100 hours total (2 hours/week/year)  
Elementary School Tutor - 12 hours total (1 hour/week/summer program)  
Student Council - 100 hours total (2 hours/week/year)  
(1000 character maximum)

**\*Of the activities listed above, which one has been the most important to you? Please tell us the following:**

- The name of the organization and your leadership role;
- How the organization positively impacts the community;
- What inspired you to participate;
- What you learned from the experience; and
- How your participation contributed to the impact of the organization.

(1000 character maximum)

**\*Do you participate in any in-school leadership activities? (Student Government, Club or Team Leader/Captain, etc.)**

NoYes

**If yes, please describe that activity**

(3971 character(s) remaining)

**\*Have you participated in any other leadership training programs (Outward Bound, National Youth Leadership Forum, National Student Leadership Conference, etc.)?**

NoYes

**\*Are you currently employed/working outside of school?**

NoYes

**\*What challenges do you see in your community and how do you see yourself addressing those challenges now and in the future?**

(1000 character maximum)

Attending the “Hemet Mayor Mentee Program,” a program designed to showcase how our city is ran, I began acknowledging that our main issues were not simply the funding, the crime rates, or \_\_\_\_ but rather the misinformation in our community. Working with the Mayor Pro Tem at that time, we consistently asked him questions about complaints that we heard from our families and community. When he showcased the difficulties of simply “fixing” the problem, we not only saw the attempts that were made but felt recognized as a community. Most of our current issues stem from a similar lack of information and extreme division and

Especially with the rise of technology, there should be much more regulation and resemblance to real human conversations and connections. In the future, I plan to advocate for policies that ensure algorithms can showcase multiple perspectives of issues within our society instead of allowing most Americans’ main source of news to become an echo chamber.

**\*Describe a leadership challenge you have encountered, how you addressed that challenge and the personal growth you achieved from facing that challenge?**

(1000 character maximum)

The most influential person in my life, my grandmother, became severely ill my sophomore year, leaving me as the head of the household with the responsibilities of taking care of my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma. With my mother in Egypt taking care of her and my father spending much of his time working, I had to balance my schoolwork, helping my sister who has trouble in school learning, and maintaining the house, along with coping with the potential loss of one of the most important figures in my life.

While it was a challenging time for me as I had to do most tasks alone, it also became an experience that allowed me to grow and develop mentally, socially, and academically. I endured and proved my capabilities until my grandma recovered and both of them came back.

This experience strengthened my ability to work through most if not all hardships that life will throw my way. I had to balance my time, work through dedication instead of motivation, and learn to work even if that success might not be seen right away, critical values that have benefited my work ethic in my current high school year and will benefit my future endeavors both throughout college and my career.

**\*Who has inspired you as a leader and what have you learned about leadership from that person?**  
(1000 character maximum)

When Representative Ted Yoho muttered that Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez was a “f\*\*\*\*\*g b\*\*\*h,” she did not let his sexism slide. Her speech, where she describes her appalling emotions as he attempted to excuse his behavior by bringing up his daughters, became influential nationwide. In this speech, one where she repeatedly does not back down on her beliefs, she showcases the unfortunate reminder that sexism is still present, even in Congress. Nevertheless, AOC’s ability to voice her repeatedly challenged beliefs influenced Representative Yoho’s decision to not run for re-election.

Since the 2020 election, AOC has become my role model. Her ability to connect with communities and give them hope in our future alongside her confidence and unwillingness to back down inspires me. Especially since AOC, like many successful leaders, began with few resources, she has taught me that leadership truly stems from courage, confidence, and the inability to back down from what we believe in.

**\*As you consider qualities of a successful leader, where do you see your opportunities for personal growth?**  
(1000 character maximum)

While I have persevered, innovated, and created an impact on others, I lack in areas that require confidence. I thrive when I feel like there is much more to be done. However, it is also that lack of confidence that needs to be changed for me to become a successful leader. It is true that “comparison is the thief of joy.” Especially in my environment, a small public charter school that succeeds based on competition, it is difficult for me to not compare my accomplishments to others around me. Accomplishments turn into stairsteps that never end, let alone become a source of confidence.

To combat this, I’ve taken steps to change my thinking. Instead of comparing my accomplishments, I simply applaud them for their actions in their own unique paths, reinforcing the idea that uniqueness is greater than uniformity. By focusing on my own path and strengths, I learn how to simply compete with myself and embrace the uniqueness I bring.

Supporting rather than competing will allow me to gain that unwavering confidence in my own abilities.

**\*Please share a personal statement focused on what you feel is the most important issue facing young people today.**  
(2000 character maximum)

“One death is a tragedy. A million deaths is a statistic.”

The drastic digitization of our lives has allowed society to find another way to misperceive, dehumanize, and divide. Two years prior, I came out as gay to my traditional Christian Egyptian parents. As a result, they took every step to control my life to ensure their child would “return to God.” They checked my phone daily, opening every app, photo, and text while also revoking my access to social media. It wasn’t until my parents threatened to move me to a

religious school or a more conservative state that I finally accepted their harsh reality: they'd rather their son forfeit his future than be gay. It was difficult to understand why they acted like this. However, seeing what they were showcased on social media made it much clearer. I saw people depicted as the root of all problems and portrayed as simply beacons of evil. Since then, I realized that the more we utilize and incorporate social media and technology into our lives, tools that were initially aimed to help connect and innovate, the more we can use real people as a distraction to hate. We simply cannot let technology, algorithms, and the highest bidder gain control of what we see, understand, and thus believe as a society. Technology needs to be handled with much more responsibility.

Technology should be a tool to help us connect more in real life rather than replace it. I plan to change the role of technology to allow for innovation without the cost of dividing society.

**\*Have you applied to the Student Leader program previously?**

NoYes

**\*Why do you want to be a Bank of America Student Leader and why should you be chosen?**

(2000 character maximum)

I lived in Egypt for the first seven years of my life. I grew up during the Egyptian Revolution of 2011. Around two years after the revolution ended, a song called "Boshret Kheir" (Good Omen) was released. The lyrics contained the names of the major cities in Egypt, talking about the "unity of the community" and the people's new ability to "create laws with their voice." The music video, released a year later, depicted many citizens holding up signs either stating the name of their city or different Arabic iterations of the word "Voice." This single song essentially became the anthem for Egyptians worldwide. It connected us and gave us an immense hope that no other song had.

Since that moment, I have not once felt unlucky to have been born with complex identities. Without them, I wouldn't have known about, let alone experience humanity's biggest strengths. I saw people, including my father, fighting for justice, helping others even when it became a disadvantage for them, and uplifting their community even through their toughest battles.

I want to be a Bank of America Student Leader to learn how to become that same forefront of change. I believe that my unique experiences and my complex identity as a queer Egyptian can be valuable for not only other Student Leaders but also others who will be inspired. For example, seeing my peers finally feel understood when I shared my story coming out, I realized just how important connections and making others feel they belong can be.

Bank of America Student Leaders will allow me to connect with much more diverse communities outside of my own and be the pathway that will allow me to pave new paths. I will gain a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to learn what it takes to truly create an impact from start to finish. I will learn how to support others and advocate for my beliefs, all while inspiring future Queer Egyptians to change the world for the better.

Growing up in a traditional environment, I was torn between my sexual orientation and my racial identity.

Over time, with perseverance and tremendous support, I learned to embrace my uniqueness as a strength. My identity as a Coptic Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so are the successful leaders who continuously paved new and unknown paths within their fields and communities.

One should not have to pick between any part of their identity in order to find a place within their community. I strive to reinforce that within my career and the communities with which I interact. By creating new paths and publicly celebrating both of my identities, I plan to share my story and become the “first” out Egyptian to create an impact through engineering. I plan to use my STEM degree to create, advocate, and lead by example for future queer Egyptians in the process.

HWC

## **Personal Statement Essay:**

**Tell us about yourself with an emphasis on your educational and/or vocational goals**

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign, and underestimating my academic abilities.

Upon researching my condition, I found out that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there were no efforts to find one.

Using the resources I had access to, I used software to create a program to treat Nystagmus. Through oscillation in text and collecting data through my Science & Engineering Fair, I was able to improve the vision of the twelve individuals with this condition. I understood the value of not just having access to resources where we can do almost anything but rather utilizing them to create what's never been done before. My experience using technology to help solve medical problems, combined with my desire for equity, paved the way for me to pursue a career in EECS & Biomedical Engineering.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. This experience drives me to advance research on rare conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receive the recognition and care they deserve. At MIT, I plan to initiate this path by presenting at the BE Career Expo to create the first glasses that can treat Nystagmus.

In a world where so many devices have become “smart,” life-saving technology should be no different. Beyond Nystagmus, I plan on developing error-resistant technology, especially

for underfunded hospitals. I plan to take MIT's "Principles and Practice of Assistive Technology" course to develop technology for individuals with disabilities. Furthermore, I will continuously utilize the skills and experiences I'll gain to turn my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

Brownm

Brown's Open Curriculum allows students to explore broadly while also diving deeply into their academic pursuits. Tell us about any academic interests that excite you, and how you might pursue them at Brown. (200-250 words)\*

“Kiro, why are you crying?” my teacher asked me in my AP Biology class. I couldn’t help it— I was struck in awe at seeing how frog zygote cells divide. From evolution to life and death, I now saw biology containing the answers to nearly every aspect of nature.

The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing makes biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore.

Similarly, technology allows for an interconnected world and an even more evolved humanity. These relatively new and complex fields allow for realities one could not have imagined even a century ago.

In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both interests, I knew that I wanted to major in Biological Engineering.

At Brown, I’ll take Biotechnology in Medicine by Dean Achilli, Tissue Engineering by Professor Hoffman-Kim, and Biomedical Engineering Design and Innovation by Professor Tripathi. Outside of academics, I’ll pursue my passion by taking advantage of Brown’s Center for Biomedical Engineering by researching Mechanobiology & Biomechanics. Brown offers an unparalleled space where my interdisciplinary interests can combine to innovate.

Students entering Brown often find that making their home on College Hill naturally invites reflection on where they came from. Share how an aspect of your growing up has inspired or challenged you, and what unique contributions this might allow you to make to the Brown community. (200-250 words)\*

Through time and perseverance, I learned how to embrace and celebrate my Egyptian culture and sexual identity simultaneously. At Brown, I look forward to connecting with LGBT students and building a community that will last for a lifetime. After high school, I will have come out to my parents. In college, I'll no longer have contact with my biological family; **I hope to find my chosen and accepting family at Brown.**

I plan to not only find the community I'll be a part of throughout my undergraduate life but also continuously accept others in places I've experienced exclusion within. My identity as an Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so is Brown's vibrant, diverse, and accepting community. I know I can celebrate every part of my identity here. I aim to connect with Middle

Eastern students, learn about how programs such as Out to Lunch are run, and gain the insight needed to make its impact greater. My goal is to expand spaces where students, like me, when searching for a community that shares their identity, can find it at Brown.

When I shared my story for the first time with peers I've connected with, I was shocked by how many people connected to my experience. Sharing my story has taught me the importance of recognition. At Brown, I'll continue sharing my story and ensuring that any Bruno going through similar hardships knows they are not alone.

Brown students care deeply about their work and the world around them. Students find contentment, satisfaction, and meaning in daily interactions and major discoveries. Whether big or small, mundane or spectacular, tell us about something that brings you joy. (200-250 words)\*

I have a thirty-minute drive to school and back home. I drive from city to city on a large, uninterrupted highway. These short periods prepare me for the day and end it with joy. From looking at my view, playing music, and even singing along to songs nonstop in my car, I go to school every day with the same energy I have when I hang out with my friends. Instead of being a long car ride, this time became an exciting part of my daily routine.

Driving and singing with music, where no one was watching, was similar to dancing in the dark in my room. Driving was not simply going from one destination to another but also a time I became excited for: a place where nothing else existed except the road, the music, and your voice. Whether I had an all-nighter to study for my AP exams or played video games with my friends the night before the last day of school, I'd play the music that motivated me to do my best. Now, I listen to the music I played during those times and gain an immersion into those memories unlike anything else.

At Brown, I plan to continue this tradition. While singing won't be a part of it, I'll continue being excited to explore everything around me. I'll continue walking across bridges such as the Providence River Pedestrian Bridge, exploring new sights, and letting the music make every day as exciting as the one before.

What three words best describe you? (3 words)\*

Adventurous, Energetic, Empathetic

What is your most meaningful extracurricular commitment, and what would you like us to know about it? (100 words)\*

"Why do your eyes shake like that?"

This was asked whenever someone focused on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. Researching my condition, I discovered that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010.

Utilizing digital oscillation and finding individuals through online support groups, I treated the Nystagmus of my twelve participants.

Presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, shocked by this recognition—a condition they never expected to be presented at a Science Fair.

My experience using technology to help solve medical problems paved the way for me to pursue a career in Biomedical Engineering.

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign.

I have Congenital Nystagmus, a genetic condition that causes uncontrollable movement of the eyes. I know what it's like being the only person at my school with this condition. Every time this question was asked, I was forced to provide the same explanation: “It's something I'm born with.”

Upon researching, I found out that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are shown that there were also no efforts to find one.

Using the resources I had access to, I created a program to treat Nystagmus. Through oscillation in text and collecting data through my Science & Engineering Fair, I was able to improve the vision of the twelve individuals with this condition. I understood the value of not just having access to resources where we can do almost anything but rather utilizing them to create what's never been done before.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair.

Experiences like these drive me to advance research on rare conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receive the recognition and care they deserve. I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine. Simply creating these devices, no matter how impactful they can be, is not enough; business and entrepreneurship skills are critical to driving real-world change. At Hopkins, I plan to advance medical technology through Biomedical engineering. I will participate in the BME Design Project Repository to potentially create the first glasses to treat Nystagmus using similar concepts.

Through equity and leadership, we can utilize our increasingly advanced, cutting-edge technology to be used for practical healthcare needs where no one is left behind.

If you could teach a class on any one thing, whether academic or otherwise, what would it be?  
(100 words)\*

Welcome to FixTech 101: Finding Solutions to Solutions

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on. This simple error caused an extremely preventable death. In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. FixTech will focus on ensuring that the technology we rely on every day is safer.

No matter what career they enter, FixTech will allow students and the people around them to shift the intense societal focus on the "new" and rather make the "old" better than it was before.

In one sentence, Why Brown? (50 words)\*

At Brown, I can simultaneously research treatment for rare conditions in the Srivastava Research Group and also begin advocacy work through Brown's Initiative for Policy, allowing me to innovate, advocate, and lead by example for future queer Egyptians in the process.

Vanderbilt

Vanderbilt University's motto, *Crescere aude*, is Latin for "dare to grow." In your response, reflect on how one or more aspects of your identity, culture, or background has played a role in your personal growth, and how it will contribute to our campus community as you dare to grow at Vanderbilt. (250 Words)

Through time and perseverance, I learned how to embrace and celebrate my Egyptian culture and identity simultaneously. At Vanderbilt, I look forward to connecting with LGBT students and communities which will provide me with a preview of the future college life I desire. After high school, I will have come out to my parents. In college, I'll no longer have contact with my biological family; **I hope to find my chosen and accepting family at Vanderbilt.**

At Vanderbilt, I plan to not only find the community I'll be a part of throughout my undergraduate life but also continuously accept others in places I was excluded from. My identity as an Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so is Vanderbilt's vibrant, diverse, and accepting community. I know I can celebrate every part of my identity at Vanderbilt. Here, I aim to connect with Middle Eastern students, learn about how programs such as the K.C. Potter Center are run, and gain the insight needed to either make it more inclusive or create my own community. My goal is to create a space where students, like me, when searching for a community that shares their identity, can find it at Vanderbilt.

When I shared my story for the first time with the peers I connected with, I was shocked by how many people related to my experience. Sharing my story has taught me the importance of recognition. At Vanderbilt, I'll continue sharing my story and ensuring that anyone going through similar hardships knows they are not alone. As a community, we can thus truly "dare to grow," leaving no one behind.

UC Apps

UC PIQ 250-350 words.: (Nov 20, 2024)

Describe how you have taken advantage of a significant educational opportunity or worked to overcome an educational barrier you have faced.

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. The conversation would completely shift to something I had no control over.

I have Congenital Nystagmus, a genetic condition that causes uncontrollable movement of the eyes. I know what it's like being the only person at my school with this condition. Every time this question was asked, I was forced to provide the same explanation: “It's just something I'm born with.” Most people reacted with a face of pity.

However, I chose not to have any accommodations. While it is a completely viable option, I wanted to challenge myself to find new ways to succeed. Without extra time or larger prints, I showcased my achievements using the same metrics as others around me. In doing so, I became more confident in not just succeeding but doing so with the additional challenges I have.

In AP Biology, we were taught that for organisms to truly survive in varying conditions, they must also adapt through learned behavior.

Sitting at the back of the class, unable to read math equations on the board, I had to depend on my imagination and listening to succeed. Thus, while I wasn't physically attentive to detail, my thought processes were. I had to adapt to succeed.

My increased imagination allowed me to understand complex ideas in my head without relying on sight. From finding simple math mistakes, picturing the Krebs cycle, and winning my school's pi memorization contest at 168 digits to recalling statements in exact detail, this adaptation allowed me to catch what many overlooked.

Through my own adaptations, Nystagmus not only became my greatest asset academically but also became my driving force to succeed. What was seen as abnormal for others was simply another part of who I was, combined with my unique strengths. My experiences serve as an example to showcase that barriers are not the end but simply obstacles we can work around.

Describe the most significant challenge you have faced and the steps you have taken to overcome this challenge. How has this challenge affected your academic achievement?

I put my phone under my pillow every night.

I used to leave it on my desk until my mother went through my phone at 4 A.M., asking about a year-old conversation. I began using the weight of my head to protect my privacy.

The next day was my first PSAT. Instead of focusing on the exam, my mind replayed that moment; fearing my future.

Two years prior, I came out as gay to my traditional Christian Egyptian parents. To ensure their child would “return to God,” they checked my phone daily and threatened to remove me from my school. For the next three years, I deleted every trace of my sexuality, wasting time scrolling through conversations for hours, rewriting years of my life. My focus shifted from academics to keeping track of every conversation.

It wasn’t until my mother traveled to Egypt that my constant fear of losing everything was alleviated. I got a glimpse of a life where I could be myself. Without the constant stress of losing everything I had, succeeding academically became much easier. When she returned, I needed her to understand my perspective.

“Who you are, your face, your eyes, it changes when you hold my phone,” I cried to my mother. She finally agreed to stop checking my phone.

Attending college programs, I came out to an entire community. My dream of being accepted for who I was became a reality. My sexuality was no longer a topic hidden as if I had committed a crime but rather a part of who I was. This period, when I was unapologetically myself, created immense hope for my future. As a result, I thrived academically. I took my last SAT with confidence, raising it by nearly 500 points.

My perseverance through adversity has motivated me to persistently take risks in both my academic and social life. As I continue my college adventures, I’ll have the space, independence, and community I’ve searched for— a place where my head is no longer simply a deadweight used to protect my privacy— and I can be myself without fear.

Think about an academic subject that inspires you. Describe how you have furthered this interest inside and/or outside of the classroom.

While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore.

In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biological Engineering.

Using my knowledge in both fields, I was able to enter my science fair with a solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus, using software. Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. I found individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook. When they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it was still, thus improving their vision.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. Beyond Nystagmus, I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine to allow our cutting-edge technology to also be used for practical healthcare needs. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, such as my mother who witnessed her coworker die due to improper use of medical technology in Egypt, my goal is to research and create medical technology that focuses on patient safety and can better provide for their needs. To me, Biomedical Engineering is not just a major but a pathway to finding cutting-edge solutions to problems that are universal to humanity.

Describe an example of your leadership experience in which you have positively influenced others, helped resolve disputes, or contributed to group efforts over time.

“I need to go to Egypt.”

As I came home from school, my mother was on the phone with the most influential person in my life. However, this time my grandmother couldn't remember her own daughter's name.

Throughout sophomore year, I was left as the head of the household with the responsibilities of taking care of my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma. With my mother now in Egypt taking care of my grandmother who was on the brink of death, and my father working overtime, I had to balance academics, helping my sister with school, maintaining the house, along with fearing the potential loss of the person I loved most.

While it was a challenging time, it also became an experience that allowed me to grow and develop mentally, socially, and academically. With a sudden increase in responsibility, it became difficult to enjoy the time I had with my peers. However, I endured and proved my capabilities while my grandma recovered and both of them came back.

Looking back, if it hadn't been for this challenge, my sister and I would not have found another opportunity to spend as much time together working towards a common goal. Although my sister and I have a near-decade age difference, through teaching, I was able to create lifelong memories with her, such as the inside jokes we made about homework mistakes. We even spent time studying together. I began taking time away from my normal routine and instead spent it with my community. This challenge not only forced me to go outside of my comfort zone but made my schedule shift entirely, thus forcing me to find new ways to succeed.

Persevering through these events strengthened my ability to work through most if not all hardships that life will throw my way. I had to balance my time, collaborate with others, and learn to work even if that success might not be seen right away, critical values that have benefited my work ethic in my current high school year and will benefit my future endeavors both throughout college and my career.

Throughout sophomore year, I was left as the head of the household with the responsibilities of taking care of my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma.

I had to balance academics, helping my sister with school, maintaining the house while fearing the potential loss of the person I loved most.

I gained critical values that have benefited my work ethic in my current high school year and will benefit my future endeavors both throughout college and my career.

Boston U

1. Reflect on a social or community issue that deeply resonates with you. Why is it important to you, and how have you been involved in addressing or raising awareness about it? (300)

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign, and underestimating my academic abilities.

Upon researching my condition, I found out that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there were no efforts to find one.

Using the resources I had access to, I used software to create a program to treat Nystagmus. Through oscillation in text and collecting data through my Science & Engineering Fair, I was able to improve the vision of the twelve individuals with this condition. I understood the value of not just having access to resources where we can do almost anything but rather utilizing them to create what's never been done before. My experience using technology to help solve medical problems, combined with my desire for equity, paved the way for me to pursue a career in Biomedical Engineering.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. This experience drives me to advance research on rare conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receive the recognition and care they deserve.

As a result, I chose not to have any accommodations. While it is a completely viable option, I wanted to challenge myself to find new ways to succeed. Without extra time or larger prints, through my own adaptations, such as relying much more on my memory and imagination rather than sight, I showcased my success using the same metrics as others around me. In doing so, I became more confident in not just succeeding but doing so with the additional challenges I had. My experiences serve as an example to showcase that barriers are not the end but simply obstacles we can work around.

1. What about the Kilachand Honors College resonates with you, and how would Kilachand's curriculum fulfill your academic, creative, intellectual, and/or professional goals? (600)

As a student who goes to an extremely rigorous charter school in California with a class size of around seventy, I have seen firsthand the countless, priceless benefits of being able to learn in a smaller environment: closer bonds with individuals and teachers, more personalized learning and help when needed, and more dedication to the students are just a few to name. Whenever I want to look into a college, I watch videos of students who go there.

For Boston University's Kilachand Honors College, I watched "Kilachand Honors College Students Get Their Own Home." Hearing stories from actual students describing the unparalleled community allowed me to correlate it to the close-knit community I have within my own high school. At BU's Kilachand, I plan to take advantage of that community, supporting each other with our own strengths and helping bridge the gap between our weaknesses.

Throughout every phase of my life, I have been fascinated with multiple disciplines and fields. Taking Academic Decathlon reinforced that interdisciplinary learning style that allowed me to see what I was learning in my own reality. Every year, we study seven subjects, from Literature to Science, centered around a single theme. This year's theme, "Our Changing Climate," has not only allowed me to gain a much deeper understanding of the political and social environment around us but also how our environment is changing scientifically in itself. Academic Decathlon has undoubtedly made me search for a liberal learning style that wouldn't tie me down to a specific field or subject. Kilachand's dedication to a liberal education will thus not only fulfill my education goals by continuously allowing me to grasp ideas through countless lenses but will give me the opportunities to research, create, and showcase ideas that can truly make an impact.

Through programs such as my Nystagmus project, I plan to work on solutions and research conditions that are often overlooked. I plan to take advantage of Kilachand's Keystone Project program to work on creating and building on my previous research with the resources, funding, and guidance I'll have to create the first glasses that can treat Nystagmus using oscillation.

Similarly, I was inspired to learn about the creative works that created change as recently as they were created; Joni Mitchell's "Big Yellow Taxi" encouraging cities to turn their parking lots into parks, Rachel Caron's *Silent Spring* effectively banning the use of DDT, and Allora's Land Mark, a community work of protest, ending the US's military occupation of Vieques, Puerto Rico has motivated me to find ways to combat change outside of simply creating new technology. Kilachand's continuous dedication to social and environmental justice will allow me to follow in the footsteps of these changemakers. For example, I plan to take advantage of the Kilachand Internship Program, using the funding that I otherwise would not have access to to create real a real impact within the communities that surround me.

Boston University's Kilachand Honors College will give me the unparalleled opportunity and space to pursue my interdisciplinary passions. It is the place in which I can research cutting-edge technology while also continuously advocating for change using the solutions that we already have. At Kilachand, I know that I can succeed through its unique programs, close-knit and supportive community, and dedication to creating an impact through every means possible.

1: Nobel laureate and BU professor Elie Wiesel once said: "There is divine beauty in learning... To learn means to accept the postulate that life did not begin at my birth. Others have been here before me, and I walk in their footsteps. The books I have read were composed by generations of fathers and sons, mothers and daughters, teachers and disciples. I am the sum total of their experiences, their quests." Is there a book, film, podcast or life- experience that has made you feel more connected to your personal history/identity, and what is the most important thing you learned from it? (600 Words)

Most films today portray straight families that might either work through conflicts together or within their family or a happy, unproblematic, and supportive family. Growing up, it was difficult to relate to either style of entertainment. My family and I would remain unproblematic as long as I remained straight. Little to no films are entered around not simply coming out to an unsupportive family but continuously working through issues like these. That was until I watched *Love, Victor*, a show that showcases a teen's journey through discovering, coming out, working through challenges, and fulfilling a life that is true to oneself.

At the beginning of the show, we see the younger Victor discover his sexuality. However, instead of trying to understand it, he continuously suppresses it. I saw myself through Victor's actions. Before I accepted my sexuality, I forced myself to create fake crushes. It was as if every time I could manufacture feelings I would feel relieved as I wouldn't have to worry about coming out.

Victor's experiences truly taught me that my experiences., one which I previously thought was unrelatable to communities outside of Middle Eastern families, were not rare. Even through a fictional portrayal, I felt the complexities of the emotions and perspectives that are created towards my parents to be recognized. For example, when Victor's father told him that he could trust him with anything, as long as it wasn't something as "bad" as being gay, Victor felt hope a second before it disappeared. I completely understand and still feel that ambiguous emotion towards my own parents. My parents were both the people who stated that no one could love me as much as them while also stating that if I were to "continue being gay," I would not be considered their child anymore. Seeing Victor persevere, come out, and inevitably become a much happier and more authentic version of himself, even with these experiences preceding it, taught me that actively working towards living one's truth far outweighs suppressing it in order to keep others satisfied.

Victor's ability to not only come out to his parents but actively fight for his identity through countless adversities has even motivated me to come out for the first time after three years of hiding it. At the beginning of my junior year, I came out to select trustworthy

individuals within my hometown who would allow me to be myself while also ensuring my safety until I graduate. Over time, however, just as Victor went from telling his closest friends to being out to an entire school, I began carefully trusting more and more people and was even out to entire communities through college programs outside of my home environment.

*Love, Victor* taught me that what may seem as essentially the end of the world could also be the moment that, over time, can cause life to change for the better. I learned that change, especially when it comes to coming out to a family that might see it as the worst thing for their child to be, is usually not quick or easy. However, no matter the results of these reactions and challenges, it will always be worth it if it results in truly embracing who you are. Victor's story, combined with the unparalleled experience of being publicly out, has not only motivated me to come out to my family when it's safe to do so but also, in college and beyond, ensure that anyone who is going through similar circumstances knows that they are not alone.

Harvard

(All 150 Words)

Harvard has long recognized the importance of enrolling a diverse student body. How will the life experiences that shape who you are today enable you to contribute to Harvard?\*

Growing up in a traditional environment, I was torn between my sexual orientation and my racial identity.

Over time, with perseverance and tremendous support, I learned to embrace my uniqueness as a strength. My identity as a Coptic Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so is Harvard's vibrant, diverse, and accepting community. I know I can celebrate every part of my identity here.

After coming out and losing contact with my biological family in college, I hope to find my chosen and accepting family at Harvard.

Finding my community and joining Harvard's SHADE and HUBBS programs, I plan to create lifelong connections, support my peers, and continuously uphold Harvard's values. I will continue to share my story and ensure that anyone going through similar hardships knows they are not alone. I will create an environment where "conditions for social transformation are created," and no one is left behind.

Describe a time when you strongly disagreed with someone about an idea or issue. How did you communicate or engage with this person? What did you learn from this experience?\*

Growing up in the Coptic Orthodox Church, my environment consisted of a divided group of conservatives. As most of my church community shared the same beliefs (pro-life, anti-LGBT), my differing beliefs made it difficult for me to connect with them on similar levels. This changed when my closest friendship with David began.

David and I often avoided controversial topics but they inevitably came up. From presidents to core church beliefs, we struggled to understand how our ideas are fundamentally different. Throughout hour-long phone calls, I began discussing the topic of abortion. Expecting another debate, I was extremely shocked to learn that we shared the same stance.

I began seeing beliefs as nuanced rather than black-and-white. Disagreement was no longer a topic I avoided. Motivated to find common ground, I began encouraging discussions to acknowledge gaps within our ideas and work towards our unanimous effort to find common solutions.

Briefly describe any of your extracurricular activities, employment experience, travel, or family responsibilities that have shaped who you are.\*

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

This was asked whenever someone focused on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. Researching my condition, I discovered that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010.

Thus, I used software to treat Nystagmus. Utilizing digital oscillation and finding individuals through online support groups, I treated the Nystagmus of my twelve participants.

Presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, shocked by this recognition—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented at a science fair.

My experience using technology to help solve medical problems, combined with my desire for equity, paved the way for me to pursue a career in Biomedical Engineering. I understood the value of not just having access to resources where we can create almost anything but also utilizing them to create what's never been done before.

How do you hope to use your Harvard education in the future?\*

If his oxygen tank had been turned on, my mom's coworker could have recovered.

When my grandma was hospitalized in Egypt, she required my mom's undivided attention to ensure no such errors occurred. In a world where devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I will use Harvard's Biomedical Engineering resources to develop error-resistant technology, especially for underfunded hospitals.

When I shared my story growing up as a queer Egyptian, I saw my peers finally feeling understood. Inspired by the leaders that Harvard creates, I also plan on paving new paths and fighting to create social impact.

At Harvard, I can pursue my interdisciplinary goals without sacrificing one or the other; I can advance medical technology in the i-lab while amplifying my voice by joining the ForumFam. My Harvard education will allow me to create, advocate, and lead by example for future queer Egyptians in the process.



Top 3 things your roommates might like to know about you.\* (150 Word Count)

I thrive where our focus is as critical as our community. Senior year has been the most eventful year of my life; you'll hear many stories with plot twists that you couldn't predict.

I'm a night owl. Studying when everything else stops allows me to focus like no other time. During those sessions, you will definitely hear Taylor Swift and Arabic music blasting through my earphones (if you're not a current Swiftie, you will be)!

When I participated in college programs, I never stopped exploring and made the most of every day. I plan to pack my day with opportunities that I can fully take advantage of at Harvard; there's no reason not to. While I might sometimes be exhausted at the end, I'll always find time to support you.

I hope our room can be a place where we can lock in, share laughs, and thrive together.

Penn State

The world faces many challenges; food insecurity, access to clean water, climate change, and health care disparities are some examples. Tell us your intended major and also how will you apply your major to address any global challenge?\*

From evolution to life and death, biology has the answers to nearly every aspect of nature. Similarly, technology allows for an interconnected world and an even more evolved humanity. These relatively new and complex fields allow for realities one could not have imagined even a century ago. While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore. In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well.

While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore.

In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biological Engineering.

Growing up in Egypt, I heard stories of helpless family members waiting outside of hospital rooms while medical care failed to save their loved ones. Sometimes it was as simple as a nurse or doctor forgetting to turn on a device, other times the machines were not enough to do the job. When my grandma was also hospitalized, she required my mother's undivided attention to ensure no such errors occurred. Every day, I see my family use technology that is critical to their survival. Testing their blood pressure and sugar which determines the amount of insulin they give themselves, if that technology had a simple bug, error, or mistake, its effects could be truly fatal.

Studying Biomedical Engineering, I plan to combine my passion for both biology and engineering while also ensuring that families don't feel the same helplessness when relying on medical technology. In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving

technology should be no different. That way, we can dramatically reduce preventative deaths, especially in underfunded hospitals and countries.

Penn State will equip me with the tools I need to create impactful, life-dependent technology that focuses on patient safety and accessibility while fulfilling every person's unique needs. I'll take my concepts, such as my Nystagmus project, to new heights. Beyond Nystagmus, I will participate in the, focusing on treatments for conditions that are often overlooked.

While technology can assist, it can unfortunately never truly cure some conditions. At Penn State's Systematic Bioengineering Laboratory, I'll work to research biological treatments and cures for conditions beyond just Nystagmus, giving hope to others with conditions that are often overlooked.

The Millennium Scholars Program provides a supportive, structured, and collaborative learning community. What strengths will you bring to the community and how will you contribute to and benefit from this collaborative environment?\*

Being a part of FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics, in my robotics team of around seven people, I was the Lead Programmer. I went from not knowing how to make the robot move to being able to code complex programs, allow the robot to extract colors from a scene, and use machine-learning models in order to get the most points. As most of my learning was self-taught, I learned just how capable I was with resources like the internet. This journey exposed me to both the challenges involved in learning an entirely new field of engineering while also showcasing the consequences that can come after hard work and dedication. However, I could not do that with the work of the builders. Similar to the way the mind is needed for the body and vice versa, we as programmers needed the physical robot to code it and our builders needed the code that ran the robot.

Due to critical connections like these, I was forced to go outside of my normal comfort zone and utilize communication in order to succeed. Now, as captain of my team, I have showcased that I know what it takes in order to lead and create a successful team.

However, my definition of success was not based on competition scores or who made it past regionals. Success is dependent on the skills we gained as a team. How we worked together, what we achieved within such a short period of time, and learning what drives us is my perspective of success. At Penn State, I plan to showcase this vision to my community. While I

will encourage dedication to achieve common goals, I will also advocate for finding the smaller achievements that are crucial to lead us to the way there.

Volunteering at my local hospital, Loma Linda University Medical Center in Murrieta, I knew that working in medicine was the right path for me. Whether it was simply discharging patients, working with families at the front desk, setting up empty patient rooms, or seeing the nurses work with them, I want to be the person who helps people when they are at their lowest, especially in the hospital where I can combine my compassion with my passion for biology. I have seen people come with balloons to celebrate a new life or flowers to deal with the loss of their loved ones. Being at the hospital was being at the forefront of life. The diverse communities I have met through simply checking people in have motivated me to gain new skills. I began learning Spanish with my peers to communicate with more diverse families. At Penn State, I plan to motivate others to take risks, motivate others to go outside of their comfort zone, meet new people, and simply try new things. If at least one action is turned into a successful skill, it can have a lifelong impact.

How has resilience played a role in your life and how do you see it affecting your college career?\*

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. The conversation would completely shift to something I had no control over.

I have Congenital Nystagmus, a genetic condition that causes uncontrollable movement of the eyes. I know what it's like being the only person at my school with this condition. Every time this question was asked, I was forced to provide the same explanation: “It's just something I'm born with.” Most people reacted with a face of pity.

However, I chose not to have any accommodations. While it is a completely viable option, I wanted to challenge myself to find new ways to succeed. Without extra time or larger prints, I

showcased my achievements using the same metrics as others around me. In doing so, I became more confident in not just succeeding but doing so with the additional challenges I have.

In AP Biology, we were taught that for organisms to truly survive in varying conditions, they must also adapt through learned behavior.

Sitting at the back of the class, unable to read math equations on the board, I had to depend on my imagination and listening to succeed. Thus, while I wasn't physically attentive to detail, my thought processes were. I had to adapt to succeed.

My increased imagination allowed me to understand complex ideas in my head without relying on sight. From finding simple math mistakes, picturing the Krebs cycle, and winning my school's pi memorization contest at 168 digits to recalling statements in exact detail, this adaptation allowed me to catch what many overlooked.

Through my own adaptations, Nystagmus not only became my greatest asset academically but also became my driving force to succeed. What was seen as abnormal for others was simply another part of who I was, combined with my unique strengths.

Even though me and my sister both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing the difficulty of finding a cure. Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. I found individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook. When they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it was still, thus improving their vision.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair.

This experience drives me to advance research on rare conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receive the recognition and care they deserve. This drive will serve as an example to showcase that any barriers, through college and beyond, are not the end but simply obstacles we can work around.

Reflect on how your unique background, experiences, and cultural perspectives have influenced your interactions with others and shaped your understanding of diversity and inclusion.\*

I put my phone under my pillow every night.

I used to leave it on my desk until my mother went through my phone at 4 A.M., asking about a year-old conversation. I began using the weight of my head to protect my privacy.

The next day was my first PSAT. Instead of focusing on the exam, my mind replayed that moment; fearing my future.

Two years prior, I came out as gay to my traditional Christian Egyptian parents. To ensure their child would “return to God,” they checked my phone daily and threatened to remove me from my school. For the next three years, I deleted every trace of my sexuality, wasting time scrolling through conversations for hours, rewriting years of my life. My focus shifted from academics to keeping track of every conversation.

It wasn’t until my mother traveled to Egypt that my constant fear of losing everything was alleviated. I got a glimpse of a life where I could be myself. Without the constant stress of losing everything I had, succeeding academically became much easier. When she returned, I needed her to understand my perspective.

“Who you are, your face, your eyes, it changes when you hold my phone,” I cried to my mother. She finally agreed to stop checking my phone.

Attending college programs, I came out to an entire community. My dream of being accepted for who I was became a reality. My sexuality was no longer a topic hidden as if I had committed a crime but rather a part of who I was. This period, when I was unapologetically myself, created immense hope for my future. As a result, I thrived academically. I took my last SAT with confidence, raising it by nearly 500 points.

My perseverance through adversity has motivated me to persistently take risks in both my academic and social life. As I continue my college adventures, I'll have the space, independence, and community I've searched for— a place where my head is no longer simply a deadweight used to protect my privacy— and I can be myself without fear.

UPenn



Haverford

**Please give us a better sense of what you are looking for in your college experience by answering the following questions:**

1. Tell us about a topic or issue that sparks your curiosity and gets you intellectually excited. How do you hope to engage with this topic or issue at Haverford? (Please limit your response to 150-200 words.)
2. We have highlighted for you some of the values that shape the Haverford community. What are some of the values you seek in your next community? How do Haverford's values, as demonstrated through our Honor Code, resonate with you?

As you think about how to answer this question, you might draw from how you have been influenced by other communities you have been a part of, experiences you may have had within your communities, or opportunities you have had to shape or even change your communities. (Please limit your response to 150-200 words.)

Bowdoin

[The Offer of the College](#) represents Bowdoin's values. You have the option to reflect on the line you selected and how it has meaning to you. (Optional, with a max of 250 words.)

Bowdoin believes that only through building a more diverse and inclusive campus community will the College best prepare graduates to be contributing and useful citizens of the world. Every graduate of this institution should be confident in their preparation to be able to navigate through differences and in all sorts of situations. A Bowdoin education does not guarantee these skills, but it does impart a set of tools necessary to bravely enter unfamiliar conditions with the confidence to deal effectively with ambiguity.

If you wish, you may share anything about the unique experiences and perspectives that you would bring with you to the Bowdoin campus and community or an experience you have had that required you to navigate across or through difference. (Optional, with a max of 250 words.)

Pomona

The Pomona-specific essay prompts for those applying for Fall 2024 admission include an academic interest statement (max. 150 words); a short-response essay (max. 150 words); and a longer-response essay (max. 250 words).

(1) Academic Interest Statement: What do you love about the subject(s) you selected as potential major(s)? If undecided, share more about one of your academic passions.

(2) What item are you excited to bring with you to college? (150 Words)

(3) Longer-Response Essay: choose to respond to one of the following three prompts in 250 words or less:

Reflecting on a community that you are part of, what values or perspectives from that community would you bring to Pomona?

Amherst

A2A

▲ Submitted

For one week at the end of January, Reed students upend the traditional classroom hierarchy and teach classes about any topic they love, academic or otherwise. This week is known as *Paideia* after the Greek term signifying “education” – the complete education of mind, body and spirit. What would you teach that would contribute to the Reed community?

Welcome to FixTech 101: A Class Dedicated to Finding Solutions to Solutions

In Egypt, one of my mom’s coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on. This simple error caused an extremely preventable death. Every day, I see my family use technology that is critical to their survival. In a world where so many devices have become “smart,” life-saving technology should be no different. FixTech will focus on ensuring that the technology we rely on every day is safer.

In this class, we will find solutions to what would be considered a solution to previous problems. We will identify, collaborate, and work towards fixing errors within the technology that exists around us. There are already many classes targeted toward advancing medicine, creating the next best thing, or even researching new cures. What about what we have now? FixTech focuses on solving the problems within the technology we use today.

We will start our class with an activity that allows each student of mine to become more aware of just how much technology they are using. I will have everyone list the devices they have with or even wearing them. Then, they will work together to create a list of problems they’ve encountered with those devices.

I will transition to the next phase of FixTech to focus on the devices that power integral parts of our society. I will give my students a simple prompt: “Present a technological failure within the past century that caused catastrophic damage.” This project will allow students to acknowledge the issue of technological problems through countless real historical events. For example, this summer, a simple error in Windows systems led to 7,000 flight delays. If it wasn’t for the update that attempted to add a new feature while overlooking the previous work, the system that countless airports and companies relied on would not have failed them. In the Chernobyl disaster, a simple test led to a power surge that killed thousands and displaced hundreds of thousands due to a poorly designed reactor and poorly trained workers. With more reliable technology and a focus on debugging rather than creating, those individuals would still be alive today.

After completing FixTech, I hope to not only make each student more aware of the “small” issues with what our society has but also do what they can to solve them. No matter what career they enter, FixTech will allow students and the people around them to shift the intense societal focus on the “new” and rather make the “old” better than it was before. In doing so, we can dedicate our time, effort, and resources to guaranteeing change rather than simply trying out different paths without “working out the quirks” within each one. I hope FixTech 101 can be a valuable commitment to Reed’s Paideia, encouraging my peers to advocate for safer and more

reliable technology. Classes like FixTech will encourage students to shift from society's normal focus and take on new experiences, challenges, and ideas.

WashLee

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

No matter who I was talking to or what I was talking about, I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign. The conversation would completely shift to something I had no control over.

I have Congenital Nystagmus, a genetic condition that causes uncontrollable movement of the eyes. I know what it's like being the only person at my school with this condition, seeing everyone focus on your explanation of something they've never seen before.

On a church trip, one of the church leaders let me use his bathroom as long as we kept it clean. In my sight, everything was spotless. However, when he pointed out the water on the floor, he said something I couldn't forget.

“Can you not see that? Are you blind? Oh wait, I forgot, you actually are blind.”

It wasn't like any other baseless comment made by my peers. This time, it was an attack directed to degrade someone I trusted and considered a leader.

The uncontrollable movement of my eyes combined with moments like these served as a constant reminder. No matter where I was, Nystagmus would be my defining characteristic the second anyone noticed the movement or its effects. Ever since I can remember, I have asked my parents why I was the only person with oscillating eyes. In response, they give me the “image within God” talk, attempting to justify something they also had control of.

In AP Biology, we were taught that for organisms to truly survive in varying conditions, they must also adapt through learned behavior.

What most don't account for is the benefits my adaptations to Nystagmus gave me. Sitting at the back of the class, being unable to read math equations on the board, I had to depend on my imagination and listening to succeed. Thus, while I wasn't physically attentive to detail, my thought processes were.

My imagination and the need to understand foundational concepts mentally gave me the ability to understand more complex ideas in my head without relying on what I could see. From simple math mistakes, picturing the Krebs cycle, winning my school's pi memorization contest at 168 digits to recalling statements in exact detail, this adaptation allowed me to catch what many overlooked.

Nystagmus, through my own adaptations, not only became my greatest asset academically but also became my driving force to search for a solution. Upon researching my condition, I found out that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Even though this condition is considered “rare,” not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are shown that there were also no efforts to find one.

Even though me and my sister both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing the difficulty of finding a cure. Using the skills I gained to learn how to code, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. Finding individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook, when they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it was still, thus improving their vision.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. This experience drives me to advance research on rare conditions, ensuring everyone is seen regardless of how rare their condition is, and receive the recognition and care they deserve.

I understood the value of not just having access to a resource, such as my computer, where I can create almost anything but rather being able to utilize it to create what's never been done before. What was seen as abnormal for others was simply another part of who I was, combined with my unique strengths as a result. My experiences serve as an example to showcase that barriers are not the end; they are simply obstacles we can work around.

Redlands

Everyone on campus – students, staff, faculty – has their “Why Redlands?” and the reason they joined the Bulldog community. What’s your “Why Redlands?”?\*

Think about the communities to which you belong. Examples might be, but are certainly not limited to: your school, neighborhood, the global community, a community of athletes, musicians, etc. Select one of your communities and tell us what makes that community beloved to you. Is there anything about that community you would change? \*

For most of my life, I’ve lived in a small town and went to a small school from sixth to twelfth grade. I have seen firsthand the benefits of being in a smaller community; closer connections to faculty, more personalized learning, and much more specialized support within my community both academically and personally.

Redlands will not only provide a small community with a location I am familiar with and have been calling home but also allow me to explore life outside of my home state. With Redland’s Engineering Combined Degree Pathway, which allows me to study at Redlands for three years and two years at another, out-of-state institution, I can get an unparalleled education that will not only get me two degrees for the costs of one but *literally* take me to new places.

In Egypt, one of my mom’s coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on. This simple error caused an extremely preventable death. When my grandma was also hospitalized, she required my mother’s undivided attention to ensure no such errors occurred. Every day, I see my family use technology that is critical to their survival. Testing their blood pressure and sugar which determines the amount of insulin they give themselves, if that technology had a simple bug, error, or mistake, its effects could be truly fatal.

In a world where so many devices have become “smart,” life-saving technology should be no different. Using my dual degree, I plan to utilize a Bachelor of Science in Biology at Redlands and create that intersection with a B.S. in Mechanical Engineering at Columbia University, gaining extensive knowledge that will aid me no matter what career path I go into while allowing me to take risks with my future innovations.

I plan to utilize Redlands’ research opportunities such as their 10-week Student Research Program. In doing so, I can not only end my undergraduate career with an interdisciplinary, complex, and unparalleled education but will be able to explore the various fields in which I can use my skills. At Redlands, I can get “the best of both worlds’ in my education and location. I know that I can thrive in a small community and, through Redlands, I can explore an entirely different environment and education.

Each Redlands student brings a diverse perspective, background, or story with them to college. How do you see yourself contributing to our community?\*

I put my phone under my pillow every night.

I used to leave it on my desk until I was jolted awake at 4 A.M. with my phone unlocked in my mother's hand. Afterward, I hoped the weight of my head would be enough to protect my privacy.

Two years prior, I came out as gay to my traditional Christian Egyptian parents. To ensure their child would "return to God," they checked my phone daily. For the next three years, I erased every trace of my sexuality, scrolling through conversations for hours, rewriting years of my life.

It wasn't until my mother traveled to Egypt that my constant fear of losing everything was alleviated. I got a glimpse of a life where I could be myself. When she returned, I had to showcase my perspective to her.

"Who you are, your face, your eyes, it all changes when you hold my phone." I cried to my mother. She finally agreed to stop checking my phone as long as I didn't "turn against God."

As life became more manageable, I yearned for a community that accepted my identity. Searching outside of my comfort zone to find it, I attended college programs, meeting students with their own stories. I did not know whether I would ever come out again or not. However, when I shared my story, I was not only shocked by the support I had but also the number of people who related to my experience. I will never forget my peers, even Middle Easterners, who offered me a home if I lost one coming out.

My dream of being understood and supported for who I was became a reality. No longer was I fighting to create a false narrative of myself, I began fighting to become a person I was comfortable being. My sexuality was no longer a topic of gossip being spread as if I had committed a crime but rather a part of who I was. This period, when I was unapologetically myself, created immense hope for my future.

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I felt as if I had to pick between my sexual orientation and my racial identity. Over time, with perseverance, and the tremendous support I have received from my closest friends, I have learned to instead embrace my identity as a strength. My identity as an Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so is Redland's vibrant, diverse, and accepting community. I know I can celebrate every part of my identity at Redlands.

After high school, I will have come out to my parents. In college, I'll no longer have contact with my biological family; I hope to find my chosen and accepting family here.

At Redlands, I plan to not only find the community I'll be a part of throughout my undergraduate life but also foster a more inclusive environment at Redland's Pride Center, accepting all identities no matter how uncommon they might be.

When I shared my story publicly for the first time, I was shocked by how many people related to my experiences. My biggest reason for coming out is the ability to share my story without fear. I plan to serve as an example to others, showcasing that perseverance can lead to success no matter the hardships. At Redlands, I'll continue sharing my story and ensuring that anyone going through similar hardships knows they are not alone.

As a student at Viterbi, I hope to create an environment where no one feels the need to sacrifice any part of their identity. I will work towards a more inclusive Egyptian and Queer community, especially in Viterbi. As a result, I can ensure that individuals going through similar hardships know that they are not alone, hoping to provide the same support I had from my peers.

Ultimately, my community and I will work towards the common goal that Viterbi sets for all: "to serve California, the nation and the world."

MIT



💙 Duke Supps

- The following question is required for all 2024-25 applicants to Duke University:
  - What is your sense of Duke as a university and a community, and why do you consider it a good match for you? If there's something in particular about our offerings that attracts you, feel free to share that as well. (250 word limit)
- We want to emphasize that the following questions are optional. Feel free to answer one or two if you believe that doing so will add something meaningful that is not already shared elsewhere in your application. Five optional questions are available – a maximum of 2 can be selected.
  - We believe a wide range of viewpoints, beliefs, and lived experiences are essential to maintaining Duke as a vibrant and meaningful living and learning community. Feel free to share with us anything in this context that might help us better understand you and what you might bring to our community.
  - Tell us about an experience in the past year or two that reflects your imagination, creativity, or intellect.
  - We believe there is benefit in sharing or questioning our beliefs or values; who do you agree with on the big important things, or who do you have your most interesting disagreements with? What are you agreeing or disagreeing about?
  - Duke's commitment to inclusion and belonging includes sexual orientation, gender identity, and gender expression. Feel free to share with us more about how your identity in this context has meaning for you as an individual or as a member of a community.
  - We recognize that not fully "fitting in" a community or place can sometimes be difficult. Duke values the effort, resilience, and independence that may require. Feel free to share with us circumstances where something about you is different and how that's influenced your experiences or identity.

Princeotn



Rice



Williams

If you are interested in submitting an example of your academic writing, you may share a 3-5 page paper written in the last year. The paper may be creative or analytical, can cover any topic, and need not be graded. Please include a description of the assignment or prompt and do not submit lab reports.

WashU



😊 Yale



FLY INS

English

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 Copy of "Why us?" Essay Research Chart 2.0 - Template to Copy

PEEP

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I always heard my friends call each other insults, especially ones where they call each other gay. At the end of my seventh-grade year, I figured out why I was not "girl crazy" like all the other guys I knew; I was gay. I felt as if I had to pick between my sexual orientation and my racial identity. With the help of my friends, teachers, and other Middle Easterners who shared a similar story, I was able to not only accept myself but also broaden my horizons. I see myself in a place I never thought I would have been able to achieve before. As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, at UPenn, I would not only be involved in communities of people who have had similar stories but would also work towards creating my community to make sure that others who are going through experiences similar to mine know that they are not alone.

## Yale In MOHTion:

Prompt 1: Why would you like to participate in the Yale in MOHTion Program? How do you think it would serve you in your college application process? (400 words or fewer)

I don't usually listen to podcasts. However, through my routine Spotify usage, I discovered a distinctive podcast. A college like Yale have a podcast dedicated to students applying to college? I tried something new and listened to *Inside the Yale Admissions Office* Podcast. I learned about Yale's emphasis on individuality when one of the Yale admissions officers, Mark, stated, "You can write the essay on the most ordinary topic but if we think we're meeting a real person, it sets the table." I gained hope, that, especially at Yale, I will be seen as an individual with my own unique personality, background, perseverance, and achievements. Not only did listening to the podcast allow me to grasp what admissions officers are looking for, but I also stopped believing that I, as a low-income first-generation student, will not be looked at as simply a number, statistic, or even graded based on my quality of writing in comparison to individuals who had access to much more resources than I did. Hearing Yale's own admissions officers emphasize to students that they should focus on being themselves instead of constantly comparing themselves to others, something that most students, including myself, have done, changed my perspective on college applications as a whole. As Yale's podcast was able to change my outlook on the commonly dreaded college applications, I am certain that attending the Yale in MOHTion Program, especially through their student groups, panels, and tours, will allow me to create timeless connections, learn more about campus life, and the students attending, and gain priceless insights and experiences into not just the admissions process but experience Yale in ways no website, video, or article could.

As a student who has worked on a project to treat an incurable condition that I have, Nystagmus, with the resources I had, computer software, it would be an invaluable opportunity to connect with individuals such as Dr. Saltzman, Pober, and Bothwell's who are also breaking through barriers such as creating artificial pancreatic islets, learn more about their work, and maybe even work with them in my future life at Yale.

As much as medicinal advancements, I am also striving to create social progression. At Yale, as an Egyptian who has had to navigate my sexuality within my culture and religion, I would not only be involved in communities of people who share similar stories (Yale's LGBT Center) but would also work towards creating my own community to ensure that others who are going through experiences similar to mine know that they are not alone. I do not doubt that if I were to be a part of Yale's community, I would not only gain a fair chance to create an impact but am also certain that I would find my chosen family and community there.

My community is the friends I met while attending the Taylor Swift Era's tour who at first were people who only shared music taste with me but became the people I now call my family. I have had to work through many obstacles in life, the biggest one is planning to come out to my entire community, including my parents, when I graduate and move to college. These friends helped me through most of these obstacles, never judging me for "planning too far ahead." They saw the entire picture of me: my background, culture, interests, and sexuality. Instead of feeling as if some part of me didn't belong in other communities, with them, I was able to embrace every part of myself.

My community has been with me through my toughest battles. From late-night talks about accepting my sexuality to sitting through church meetings that actively condemned actions such as simply being in love. Before I met them, I would always feel inferior to my other church friends for feelings I could not control. However, I distinctly remember when an event like this occurred again after meeting them. My community, through their vulnerability, discussed their own similar experiences in which they too were told that who they love can become an "unforgivable" sin. I have also struggled with seeing my future outside of high school; in a way, I was able to stay within the physical care of my parents while being somewhat out in my school community. However, while I didn't know it at the time, through this community, with someone who has specifically gone through a nearly identical situation, I, for the first time, saw a better version of myself in college.

I became immensely grateful that I have not only found a community that shares similar interests with me, but, almost like separated twins, have gone through similar experiences and made it out better than they ever were before. My community, while small, has truly been with me through thick and thin. If it weren't for them, I would not have been able to see myself as equal to my Middle Eastern friends, see a life outside of high school, or be able to accept both my sexuality and culture without choosing one or the other. From sharing the songs we like, talking about our crushes and accomplishments, to even the deepest topics, these are the people that I can call my community.



## ECs:

Computer/Technology: Using Oscillation to Treat Nystagmus - STEM EXPO

Time: 10th, 11th Timing School: 1-5 hrs/wk, 8 months; Summer: 1-5 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: Using software I created to treat Nystagmus, I have worked on this project for two years

Significant Events/Awards: Silver Award in my Riverisde's Science and Engineering Fair in both 10th and 11th Grade

Computer/Technology: FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics

Grades: 11th

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 7 months; Summer: 1-5 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: Programming and maintaining the entire robot using Java to perform complex tasks and earn points

Positions: 11th: First Chair/Section Leader

Significant Events/Awards: Lead Programmer in Robotics, First Place: Motivate Award

Academic: Academic Decathlon

Grades: 11th

Timing: School: 11-15 hrs/wk, 10 months; Summer: 1-5 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: Participate in local, county, and state competitions, Learn and test on seven subjects

Significant Events/Awards: First Place: 11th, Riverside County Champions

Computer/Technology: Coding Club - Founder

Grades: 11th

Timing: School: 1-5 hrs/wk, 10 months

Description/Role: Collaborate with teams to create useful programs for our school, Teach coding and its importance

Positions: 11th: Founder/Co-Founder

Significant Events/Awards: Founder: 11th, Coding Club

Community Service (Volunteer): Volunteer at Loma Linda Hospital

Grades: 11th

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 10 months; Summer: 6-10 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: Greeted and assisted patients, families, and visitors, Discharged patients and maintained cleanliness

Courses:

2024 (Summer):

Introduction to Psychology (Dual Enrollment)

Arabic I (Dual Enrollment)

2024-2025

Arabic II (Dual Enrollment) One Semester)

English 101 & 103 (Dual Enrollment) (One Per Semester)

AP U.S. Government and Politics (One Semester)

AP Macroeconomics (One Semester)

AP Chemistry

AP Calculus B/C

AP Environmental Science

Academic Decathlon



Voice of Tufts:

Community Service (Volunteer): Volunteer at Loma Linda Hospital

Grades: 11th

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 10 months; Summer: 6-10 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: Greeted and assisted patients, families, and visitors, Discharged patients and maintained cleanliness

Computer/Technology: FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics

Grades: 11th

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 7 months; Summer: 1-5 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: Programming and maintaining the entire robot using Java to perform complex tasks and earn points

Positions: 11th: Lead Programmer

Significant Events/Awards: Lead Programmer in Robotics, First Place: Motivate Award

I work a part-time job at a Poki place in order to pay for things like my gas and other essentials.

My grandmother became severely ill in the second semester of my sophomore year, leaving me as the head of the household with the responsibility of taking care of my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma.

As my parents also worked most of the time, I was unable to do many extracurriculars until I got my license at the beginning of my junior year.

In 250 words or less, tell us about 1-2 academic subjects you enjoy and hope to explore during your undergraduate education at Tufts. Why do these fields of study excite you?

While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore. In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biomedical Engineering. Using my knowledge in both fields, I was able to enter my science fair with a solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus, using software. At Tufts, I plan on pursuing my passion for engineering and biology through Tufts' Biomedical Engineering program. To me, Biomedical Engineering is not just a major but a pathway to finding cutting-edge solutions and skills in almost any career. Seeing how researchers at Tufts could

use something as simple as paper to take vital measurements, I am inspired to create medical history in the same way they did, no matter how impossible it seems.

Washington & Lee

In my sixth-grade science class, my teacher told me I could only ask 5 questions a day, a number simply too low for my curiosity,

Throughout my educational path, I was always the student who asked the most questions. I've never really felt ashamed when asking any question. Most of them started with "Why?" or "How?" It didn't feel enough to just know something was true; I wanted to know how people like me and everyone else could come to such conclusions. Whether it's scientific advancements or mathematical laws, discovering the different kinds of Amino Acids or the various functions being graphed, for me to understand these foundational concepts and set them in my mind, I needed to know what led to these individuals' understandings.

Since seventh grade, I realized something different about myself that made me like no other Egyptian person from my local church. I discovered that I was bisexual.

In this case, no matter how many questions I asked, I could not get the answers I needed. I wanted to know why, out of essentially everyone around me, I was the one who had to be born with something so frowned upon. I searched for an answer only I could provide. I had to search within myself and the variety of experiences from others to fully understand and educate myself. This drove my desire for answers in both my academic and personal life even further. Instead of just asking questions, I wanted to find answers to the "impossible" ones. After accepting who I am, I feel confident that I can break through the boundaries of almost anything.

While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide.

The fact that all of us and our environment originated from a single cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt as if there was so much more to explore. In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biomedical Engineering.

It is difficult to only focus on one factor that defines who I am. I am not just my sexuality, major, experiences, family, experiences. I am, however, the combination of all of these. In college, I plan to never stop asking questions, seek answers to "impossible" questions, continue pursuing and shaping my passions, stay true to myself, and remain a role model for others.

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What I love about colleges like Washington and Lee is that they genuinely make an effort to leave no student behind, no matter their background. and Lee represent what all colleges should be; they foster an environment to cultivate learning. Because of opportunities like DIVE, I gained a feeling like no other knowing that no matter what my family's income is, a factor that I have little control over, what I do have control over is my future, career, and life is not limited to what I was born into.

“The world doesn’t revolve around you.”

The foundations of my relationship with this person crumbled. I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but couldn’t; I refused to continue excusing these comments and decided to face reality. Growing up in an Egyptian household where men’s feelings are often disregarded made finding my own identity challenging. Instead of supporting the person I was becoming, my own family undermined my independence, and the struggles I faced in school and my personal life were often seen as irrelevant and unimportant compared to “my relationship with God.” These actions, however, would only fuel the fires of self-doubt, and the struggle to find my identity.

Since realizing my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang’s relationship, “my person.” I yearned for someone who willingly listened to my struggles, shared the joy of my accomplishments, and talked non-stop about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for an explanation. From school friends to my church’s youth group, I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn’t choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.” In my early high school years, I depended on my friends from church to accept me, so I had no choice but to accept myself too. Unfortunately, as with the struggles of being an unconventional person, I would have to become desensitized to whole communities rejecting me, including that one.

I had to search outside my “permitted locations” to find my community. In doing so, I put myself out there, fearing next to nothing. I found communities with the most diverse people I have seen, even people who are also applying to college just like me. It became a feeling like no other to feel that I am truly not alone. With the help of my friends, teachers, and most importantly, my support, I learned to accept and depend on myself rather than others. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside of my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, no matter what college I go to, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone the same way I did. No matter one’s biology identity, or background, no one should feel excluded from the spaces that make them who they are. Being in college and a part of programs such as Washington & Lee’s LGBT Center will give me the space I’ve searched for to come out and embrace my identity both as an Egyptian and a bisexual.

## RICE

We are interested in learning more about you and the context in which you have grown up, formed your aspirations and accomplished your academic successes. Please describe the factors and challenges that have most shaped your personal life and aspirations. (300 word limit)

“The world doesn’t revolve around you.”

The foundations of my relationship with this person crumbled. I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but couldn’t; I refused to continue excusing these comments and decided to face reality. Growing up in an Egyptian household where men’s feelings are often disregarded made finding my own identity challenging. Instead of supporting the person I was becoming, my own family undermined my independence, and the struggles I faced in school and my personal life were often seen as irrelevant and unimportant compared to “my relationship with God.” These comments, however, would only fuel the fires of self-doubt, and the struggle to find my identity.

Since realizing my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang’s relationship, “my person.” I yearned for someone who willingly listened to my struggles, shared the joy of my accomplishments, and talked non-stop about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for an explanation. From school friends to my church’s youth group, I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn’t choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.” In my early high school years, I depended on my friends from church to accept me, so I had no choice but to accept myself too. Unfortunately, as with the struggles of being an unconventional person, I would have to become desensitized to whole communities rejecting me, including that one

With the help of my friends, teachers, and most importantly, my support, I learned to accept and depend on myself rather than others. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside of my control and became much more tolerant of change. Being in college will give me the space I’ve searched for to come out, and the distance from my family will allow me to create a safety net. At Rice, I will dedicate my involvement to inclusive communities of people who’ve experienced many of the same challenges I have faced such as their Queer Resource Center. In doing so, I want to create a supportive environment where people, no matter where they are from, can feel seen, even if we don’t make the majority statistic.

### **Tell Us Why You Are Interested in Rice. (No Word Count)**

In Egypt, one of my mom’s coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man’s life. My grandma, who was hospitalized for four months in a neighboring hospital, required my mom’s complete and undivided attention to make sure no such simple error occurred. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, I hope to create error-resistant technology that can not only help overwhelmed doctors but also allow them to focus on what requires their attention more

Studying bioengineering, I want to ensure families never feel the same helplessness when relying on medical technology. In a world where so many devices have become “smart,”

life-saving technology should be no different. That way, we can dramatically reduce preventative deaths, especially in underfunded hospitals and countries.

Taking Rice's BIOE 449 (Troubleshooting Workshop for Clinically-Relevant Biomedical Equipment) course, my peers and I can not only learn about how to work with and construct biomedical equipment, but also become trained to do the more difficult task of solving issues within those devices. Like the difficulty of finding and fixing bugs in code, taking a class like BIOE 449 is crucial for a more complete understanding of the equipment that we readily work with. In the same way that medical screws allowed my grandma to walk again, I want to be able to transform people's lives through the technology I work with and create.

Creating an impact isn't about knowing the most information, it's about being able to bridge the gaps found between them. As a student who is also interested in business, I'm excited to take Rice's BIOE 493 (Biomedical and Biotechnology Startups) course. Being able to utilize and combine each of my passions for entrepreneurship, biology, and technology makes me confident in my abilities without having to sacrifice any part of it, which Rice strives to do.

#### EC: Campaigning

In our local Hemet Mayor Mentee Program, a program dedicated to teaching students about government and local city issues, I worked with a fellow city council member. In doing so, some of my peers and I were interested in campaigning for him. With our diverse perspectives, knowledge about the city, and communication skills we worked on spreading awareness of local city issues such as homelessness, and showcasing how our candidate plans to reduce it. Campaigning with this candidate allowed me to see the hard work and effort required to truly learn about our city, even with its smaller size. From the city's finances to street plans, one of the biggest lessons I learned is that executing a proposed solution is not as simple as most people perceive. There is so much more planning that has to be executed first for a solution to take place. However, this was only the beginning. After learning about the ins and outs of Hemet, we set out to campaign with individuals within the local district. In doing so, we learned about the issues that mattered to citizens the most and ensured that their voices and concerns were heard. I plan to keep campaigning until the election takes place and will continue gaining priceless communication skills with the diverse individuals I speak with.

While volunteering at my local hospital, I knew that working in medicine was the right path for me. Whether it was simply discharging patients, working with families at the front desk, setting up empty patient rooms, or seeing the nurses work with them, I want to be the person who helps people when they are at their lowest, especially in the hospital where I can combine my compassion with my passion for biology. I have seen people come with balloons to celebrate a new life or flowers to deal with the loss of their loved ones. Being at the hospital is being at the forefront of life.

In a couple of paragraphs, discuss your interest in visiting Wesleyan and what you hope to gain from the experience.

Upon looking through QuestBridge's partner colleges, I came across Wesleyan University. Over the summer, I have stressed countless hours about my inability to decide on one major. I felt that picking a single major would tie me down to a specific field when what makes me who I am is my passion for multiple fields. With my passion for biology and technology, I did not want to pick one or the other. I want to gain the deepest understanding in both fields. Upon researching Wesleyan's major offerings, I found the unique trait that this university has that made me decide to apply there.

At Wesleyan, I am planning to pursue its dual degree programs for Engineering. Through WesExplore, I not only plan to explore this university and everything that it offers but also be able to speak directly to the various professors who have dedicated their lives to their passions to discover where I fit in most. Unfortunately, without programs like these, I am unable to see most careers myself due to my financial status and location.

It's hard to move forward when in the back of your mind, you're constantly being told there's no way out. I've always felt I'd be stuck within the boundaries of my underfunded town, thinking my life would always remain stagnant, and financial instability would be its driving force. However, I know that I am not contained in my current world. This program will connect me to like-minded peers while also allowing me to meet people with perspectives I haven't seen before. It will teach me that I am not alone in my current situation, even with my background. I am certain that by participating in this program and furthering my interests in biology and engineering, while also learning about everything that Wesleyan University has to offer, including support for a transition to college, I will gain a priceless experience to truly better prepare me as a student and even a future leader.

Location and Biology: Our social location and biological makeup intersect to "place us" in the world, shaping our identities and our sense of belonging. Reflect on your own location and biology: how have these two aspects influenced your worldview, the communities you are part of, and the paths you have chosen? In what ways have your location and biology led to your exclusion from spaces you have desired to enter? (Optional)

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I always heard my friends call each other insults, especially ones where they call each other gay. At the end of my seventh-grade year, I figured out why I was not "girl crazy" like all the other guys I knew; I was gay. I felt as if I had to pick between my sexual orientation and my racial identity. It was as if, no matter where I physically resided, my location remained the same, a home with parents who would not love me if I became myself. Since realizing my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang's relationship, "my person." I yearned for

someone who willingly listened to my struggles, shared the joy of my accomplishments, and talked non-stop about life.

This deep need was the consequence of my search for an explanation. From school friends to my church's youth group, I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a "sin" I didn't choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a "good Christian man." In my early high school years, I depended on my friends from church to accept me, so I had no choice but to accept myself too. Unfortunately, as with the struggles of being an unconventional person, I would have to become desensitized to whole communities rejecting me because of my biology, including that one.

I had to search outside of my "permitted locations" to find my community. In doing so, I put myself out there, fearing next to nothing. I found communities with the most diverse people I have seen, even people who are also applying to college just like me. It became a feeling like no other to feel that I am *truly* not alone. As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, no matter what college I go to, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone the same way I did. No matter their biology or location, no one should feel excluded from the spaces that make them who they are.

WISE:

Why are you interested in attending the WISE program? \* (225 Words)

While participating in the FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics, we had a meeting with one of our school's alumni who currently goes to MIT. That day, I realized that I too could make it to a university like MIT; it wasn't impossible. I felt constrained within the boundaries of my underfunded town, thinking my life would always remain stagnant, and financial instability would be its driving force. However, seeing people I know achieve their dreams, I know that I am not confined in my current world.

The WISE program will provide insight into MIT's community in a way no website or video could. For example, after our robotics meeting, I watched Gohar's "A Day in the Life of an MIT Senior" and envisioned myself at MIT. It would be an incredible opportunity to experience MIT in person and connect with other students who are passionate about their future there. The WISE program will also allow me to meet role models and professors with unique perspectives and passions which can inspire me and pave the way for my career path. Programs like WISE prove that people who share my circumstantial background are able to persevere and succeed, even at MIT. WISE will equip me with the connections, skills, and experience to prepare me for more than just college life.

What experiences have most shaped your educational journey thus far? \*

While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore. In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biological Engineering. Using my knowledge in both fields, I was able to enter my science fair with a solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus, using software.

Seeing how researchers at MIT could use something as simple as paper to take vital measurements, I am inspired to create medical history in the same way they did, no matter how impossible it seems.

Based on your previous answer, why does this major/department at MIT interest you most? How does this major/department contribute to your interest in STEM (the fields of science, technology, engineering, and mathematics)? \*  
(200 words or fewer)

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized for four months in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's complete and undivided attention to make sure no such simple error occurred. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, I hope to create error-resistant technology that can not only help overwhelmed doctors but also allow them to focus on what requires their attention more. Studying bioengineering, I want to ensure families never feel the same helplessness when relying on medical technology. In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. That way, we can dramatically reduce preventative deaths, especially in underfunded hospitals and countries. At MIT's Chemical-Biological Engineering Department, I am excited to take the Biological Engineering Projects Laboratory (CI-M) course. In doing so, I plan to create technology that can better assist both the patients and the doctors. I want to be able to transform people's lives through the technology I work with and create

(100 Words) No application can meet the needs of every individual. If you think that additional information will give us a more thorough impression of you, please include it here.

I was unable to do most of my extracurriculars until I was able to get my license at the beginning of my junior year when I legally could. My father, with his busy work schedule, and my mother staying at home to take care of my grandma were unable to drive me to places outside of school.

If you had unlimited money to start your own business, what would it be and why? \*

At MIT, I plan to take advantage of the skills that I learn and utilize them to create a business. If I had unlimited money to start a business, I would start a business that works on treating and even curing rare conditions such as Nystagmus. As a person living with Congenital Nystagmus, I know the struggle of not only being told there is no cure for my condition, but that there is also little effort in finding treatments or cures. My business would not only use this money to fund research for Nystagmus but also ensure that every condition and biological problem is taken care of. I would do everything in my power to transform people's lives, including my own, for the better. Since money will not be an issue, I would also ensure that everyone can access these treatments no matter their financial status or where they live.

This award is given by QuestBridge for students who have excelled academically despite their financial hardships or background. This award also allows students to gain the skills they need to not only apply to college but also to QuestBridge's National College Match program.

Volunteering, whether it was simply discharging patients, working with families at the front desk, setting up empty patient rooms, or seeing the nurses work with them, I realized that I want to be the person who helps people when they are at their lowest with a career in medicine.

This award is given to students to recognize the top 20 juniors in relation to their weighted GPA.

This is a team that makes a collective effort to make FIRST known throughout their school and community and sparks others to embrace the culture of FIRST. This award is given to teams that embrace STEM and robotics throughout their community.

Williams:

Using software, I worked on a treatment for a currently incurable condition, Congenital Nystagmus. I have entered this project two years in a row in my Science & Engineering Fair and have gotten County Silver Awards in both years. Here is the website for the project:

[sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/](https://sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/)

Being a part of FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics, in my robotics team of around seven people, I was the Lead Programmer. I went from not knowing how to make the robot move to be able to code complex programs, allow the robot to extract colors from a scene, and use machine-learning models in order to get the most points. As most of my learning was self-taught, I learned just how capable I was with resources like the internet. This journey exposed me to both the challenges involved in learning an entirely new field of engineering while also showcasing the consequences that can come after hard work and dedication.

Volunteering at my local hospital, Loma Linda University Medical Center in Murrieta, I knew that working in medicine was the right path for me. Whether it was simply discharging patients, working with families at the front desk, setting up em in pty patient rooms, or seeing the nurses work with them, I want to be the person who helps people when they are at their lowest, especially in the hospital where I can combine my compassion with my passion for biology. I have seen people come with balloons to celebrate a new life or flowers to deal with the loss of their loved ones. Being at the hospital is being at the forefront of life.

Please respond to the following in no more than 300 words: "There are just under four thousand 4-year colleges and universities in the United States. Being as specific as possible, what interests you most about Davidson College?"\*

As a student who goes to an extremely rigorous charter school in California with a class size of around seventy, I have seen firsthand the benefits of being able to learn in a smaller environment: closer bonds with individuals and teachers, more personalized learning, and help when needed, and more dedication to the students are just a few to name. Whenever I want to look into a college, I watch videos of students who go there. For Davidson, I watched "Why did you Choose Davidson?" and realized that this is a college I want to apply to because of its similar rigor and smaller class size.

At college, I do not want to be tied down to a single major. I am excited to take advantage of Davidson's Double Major opportunity. What I love about liberal arts colleges is their ability to provide a more well-rounded education instead of a tied-down education for one major or field. I see myself doing a variety of fields, each one with its unique passion and I cannot imagine having to choose only one this early in my career. At Davidson, I am excited to pursue a Double Major in Biology and Economics with a minor in Computer Science.

As medical school will be one of my main potential career paths, I am fascinated to know that Davidson has an almost double-than-average rate of acceptance to medical schools. I also know that if I did not score as well on one of my MCATs, Davidson would provide me with another opportunity before I even apply to medical school. I plan to be a part of Davidson's Research in Science Experience (RISE) program where I believe I can truly make a difference in medicine through both my unique insights and the ideas of others.

:

**Briefly** list the extracurricular activities and/or work experience that you have been most active with in high school. Please also include relevant leadership positions.

Babson

**Short statement:** How would you benefit from attending Access Babson? What are you hoping to get out of your time in this program? (250 words maximum)

While attending Temecula's Medical Career Pathways summer program to explore my various career paths, I learned about the importance of networking, even in medicine. Hearing what a panel of individuals only a few years older than me had to say about their paths profoundly changed my perspective on my career path and the skills I need no matter where I go. One statement that stood out to me was, "You can learn biology, computer science, basically anything no matter what college you go to. What matters most is the connections you make at that college."

As the captain of my robotics team and founder of my school's Coding Club, I gained foundational knowledge of technical, leadership, and innovative skills with the diverse communities I worked with. However, what I lack most is my entrepreneurship skills. For me to create a successful startup using my skills and strengths, I need to bridge the gap between my business and technological skills. At Babson, with its educational emphasis on entrepreneurship, marketing, and management skills, I can develop a vigorous business plan that can utilize my strengths.

Access Babson will not only allow me to learn more about business but also provide me with priceless connections amongst like-minded and diverse peers, and professors who have dedicated their lives towards their passions in business, and explore life at Babson College. My time in this program will provide me with lifelong lessons, preparing me to innovate and become a leader in the technology industry.

Edits:

While attending Temecula's Medical Career Pathways summer program, I learned about the importance of networking, even in medicine. Hearing what a panel of individuals only a few years older than me had to say about their paths profoundly changed my perspective on my career path and the skills I need regardless of where I go. One statement that stood out to me was, "You can learn biology, computer science, basically anything no matter what college you go to. What matters most is the connections you make at that college."

As the captain of my robotics team and founder of my school's Coding Club, I gained foundational knowledge of technical, leadership, and innovation skills with many diverse communities I worked with. With the skills I already have, what I need more experience with is entrepreneurship. In order for me to create a successful startup using my skills and strengths, I need to bridge the gap between my business and technological skills. At Babson, with its emphasis on entrepreneurship, marketing, and management skills, I can create a successful business that can utilize my strengths.

Access Babson will not only allow me to explore campus life at Babson College but also provide me with the opportunity to forge priceless connections amongst like-minded and diverse peers, and professors who have dedicated their lives towards their passions in business. My time in this program will provide me with lifelong lessons, preparing me to innovate and become a leader in the technology industry.

**Short statement:** Why are you interested in studying business? Briefly tell us about your passions and goals. (250 words maximum)

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's undivided attention to make sure no similar errors occurred.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine to allow our cutting-edge technology to also be used for practical healthcare needs, as shown through my Nystagmus project. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, my goal is to create medical technology that focuses on patient safety and can better provide for their needs.

While my technical and leadership skills have prepared me to create strong innovative ideas, I recognize the importance of being able to turn innovative ideas into successful ventures. Simply creating these devices, no matter how impactful they can be, is not enough; business and entrepreneurship skills are critical to driving real-world change.

Studying business will provide me with essential entrepreneurship, marketing, and management knowledge which will equip me with the skills I need to pitch my ideas, market, connect with potential partners, and adapt to our constantly changing global economy. By combining my strengths in technology with the knowledge I will gain by studying business, I can make a genuine impact on the lives of countless individuals.

Edits:

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's undivided attention to make sure no similar errors occurred.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine to allow our cutting-edge technology to also be used for practical healthcare needs, as shown through my Nystagmus project. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, my goal is to create medical technology that focuses on patient safety and can better provide for their needs.

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I am a QuestBridge College Prep Scholar. This award is given by QuestBridge for students who have excelled academically despite their financial hardships or background. This award also allows students to gain the skills they need to not only apply to college but also QuestBridge's National College Match program.

I am a part of my school's honor court. This award is given to students to recognize the top 20 juniors concerning their weighted GPA.

I work a part-time job at a Poki place to pay for things like my gas and other essentials.

My grandmother became severely ill in the second semester of my sophomore year, leaving me as the head of the household with the responsibility of taking care of my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma.

As my parents also worked most of the time, I was unable to do many extracurriculars until I got my license at the beginning of my junior year.

Computer/Technology: Using Oscillation to Treat Nystagmus - STEM EXPO

Description/Role:

When I took AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in Biomedical Engineering. Using my knowledge, I was able to enter my STEM EXPO project with a software solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus. Nystagmus is a neurological condition that causes an involuntary movement of the eyes, usually oscillating back and forth. My project focuses on finding treatments and solutions to help improve the vision of individuals with Congenital Nystagmus, who make up the majority of the 5% of the population that has this condition.

While there are treatments for acquired Nystagmus, that is not the case for Congenital Nystagmus. I've created a program in code.org to showcase my proposed solution. This program, through the use of oscillation of text, can improve the effects of Nystagmus. With this project, I was able to win two silver awards at my county's Science & Engineering Fair.

Here is the website link that has my entire project:

[sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/home](https://sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/home) .

200+ Hours

Community Service (Volunteer): Volunteer at Loma Linda Hospital

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 10 months; Summer: 6-10 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role:

Volunteering at my local hospital, Loma Linda University Medical Center in Murrieta, I knew working in medicine was the right path for me. Whether it was simply discharging patients, working with families at the front desk, setting up empty patient rooms, or seeing the nurses work with them, I want to be the person who helps people when they are at their lowest, especially in the hospital where I can combine my compassion with my passion for biology. I have seen people come with balloons to celebrate a new life or flowers to deal with the loss of their loved ones. Being at the hospital is being at the forefront of life.

Computer/Technology: FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 7 months; Summer: 1-5 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role: In my robotics team of around seven people, I was the Lead Programmer. I went from not knowing how to make the robot move to being able to code complex programs, allow the robot to extract colors from a scene, and use machine-learning models to get the most points.

Positions: 11th: Lead Programmer 12th: Captain

Significant Events/Awards:

First Place: Motivate Award: The Motivate Award is given to a team makes a collective effort to make FIRST known throughout their school and community and sparks others to embrace the culture of FIRST. This award is given to teams that embrace STEM and robotics throughout their community.

Community Service (Volunteer): National Honors Society

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk, 10 months; Summer: 1-5 hrs/wk, 2 months

Description/Role:

As a National Honor Society member, our school collaborates with our local museum and elementary schools to create "Science Nights" and "Science Saturdays." In these monthly events, we work with younger children in stations that we set up relating to STEM. In doing so, we aim to get our future generation more involved and motivated in learning about STEM and create a long-lasting impact in which they believe they can make the impossible possible. For example, in the stations that we set up, from optical illusions, lasers, and mirrors, to creating their electrical boards, what, to these children, would seem difficult if not impossible for them to do themselves, is something that they have now accomplished.



## CalTech Up Close

Creativity is a cornerstone at Caltech. Techers are at the forefront of finding creative solutions to society's challenges. Tell us about how you have been creative in your life.

When I took AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in Biomedical Engineering. Using my knowledge, I was able to enter my STEM EXPO project with a software solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus. Nystagmus is a neurological condition that causes an involuntary movement of the eyes, usually oscillating back and forth. My project focuses on finding treatments and solutions to help improve the vision of individuals with Congenital Nystagmus, who make up the majority of the 5% of the population that has this condition.

While there are treatments for acquired Nystagmus, that is not the case for Congenital Nystagmus. I've created a program to showcase my proposed solution. This program, through the use of oscillation of text, was able to improve the effects of Nystagmus on twelve individuals. With this project, I was able to win two silver awards at my county's Science & Engineering Fair.

Here is the website link that has my entire project:  
[sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/home](https://sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/home)

Harvey-Mudd

In 500 words or less, describe the community in which you were raised. In what ways has your community/background informed your goals, beliefs, ideas and perspectives?\*

“The world doesn’t revolve around you.”

The foundations of my relationship with this person crumbled. I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but couldn't; I refused to continue excusing these comments and decided to face reality. Growing up in an Egyptian household where men's feelings are often disregarded made finding my own identity challenging. Instead of supporting the person I was becoming, my own family undermined my independence, and the struggles I faced in school and my personal life were often seen as irrelevant and unimportant compared to “my relationship with God.” These actions, however, would only fuel the fires of self-doubt, and the struggle to find my identity.

Since realizing my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang's relationship, “my person.” I yearned for someone who willingly listened to my struggles, shared the joy of my accomplishments, and talked non-stop about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for an explanation. From school friends to my church's youth group, I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn't choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.” In my early high school years, I depended on my friends from church to accept me, so I had no choice but to accept myself too. Unfortunately, as with the struggles of being an unconventional person, I would have to become desensitized to whole communities rejecting me, including that one.

I had to search outside my “permitted locations” to find my community. In doing so, I put myself out there, fearing next to nothing. I found communities with the most diverse people I have seen, even people who are also applying to college just like me. It became a feeling like no other to feel that I am *truly* not alone. With the help of my friends, teachers, and most importantly, my support, I learned to accept and depend on myself rather than others. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside of my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, no matter what college I go to, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone the same way I did. No matter their biology location, or background, no one should feel excluded from the spaces that make them who they are. Being in college will give me the space I've searched for to come out, and the distance from my family will allow me to create a safety net.

## Bates

\*Prologue to Bates is a highly selective program and will provide you with wonderful insight into the Bates community. What do you hope to gain from this experience? (Essay should be between 300 and 500 words)

From evolution to life and death, biology has the answers to nearly every aspect of nature. Similarly, technology allows for an interconnected world and an even more evolved humanity. These relatively new and complex fields allow for realities one could not have imagined even a century ago. Growing up in Egypt, I heard stories of helpless family members waiting outside of hospital rooms while medical care failed to save their loved ones. Sometimes it was as simple as a nurse or doctor forgetting to turn on a device, other times the machines were not enough to do the job. With cutting-edge technological developments, why are life-saving devices so expensive and often inadequate?

I am determined to create life-saving technology. A deep education at the intersection of biology and technology will be the first step to achieving that goal. Bates' Combined Plan would allow me that opportunity. With the freedom to explore, I can study biology and engineering under the tutelage of pioneers, such as Dr. Wenzel's impactful research on neurobiological mechanisms. Prologue to Bates will allow me to meet some of the faculty I may one day be fortunate enough to learn from.

We learn as much from our peers as from our instructors. I hope to surround myself with driven, passionate, and like-minded friends in places like Bates' Robotics Club. Attending Prologue to Bates, I would have the incredible opportunity to connect with students in these clubs and learn about the paths they have forged at Bates. Without these programs, I am unable to visit and experience Bates myself due to the financial burden it would impose on my family.

I've always felt I'd be stuck within the boundaries of my small town, thinking my life would always remain motionless, and financial instability would be its driving force. It's hard to move forward when in the back of your mind, you're constantly being told there's no way out. However, through determination, perseverance, and allowing myself to take risks, I learned that I am not contained in my current world. One of those risks I took was allowing myself to navigate my sexuality within my culture as a Christian Egyptian. As I will also officially come out as bisexual and will not be in contact with my family, at Bates, I plan to explore SPARQ and learn more about the support they have to offer. Through SPARQ, I hope to find a community and foster a more inclusive one with my unique perspectives and background.

Prologue to Bates will not only connect me to like-minded peers but also allow me to meet people with perspectives I haven't seen before. It will teach me that I am not alone in my current circumstances. By participating in this program and learning about everything that Bates has to offer, including the city surrounding it, campus life, and the experiences of its students, I will gain priceless insights and experiences (including eating at the dining hall) in ways no website, video, or article could.

Pomona;

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I always heard my friends call each other insults, especially ones where they call each other gay. At the end of my seventh-grade year, I figured out why I was not "girl crazy" like all the other guys I knew; I was gay. Back then, just the word itself was one of the worst things to call someone, let alone identify as one. I struggled with the feeling that I was "inferior" to others simply because of my sexuality, especially as someone who was raised to never "conform" to "Western" values. I felt as if I had to pick between my sexual orientation and my racial identity.

Over time and perseverance, I learned to be able to not only accept who I am but also celebrate my culture at the same time without pulling away from one or the other. With the help of my friends, teachers, and other Middle Easterners who shared a similar story, I was able to not only accept myself but also broaden my horizons and I see myself in a place where I never thought I would have been able to achieve before.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, at Bowdoin, through programs such as Q&A, I will work towards creating an inclusive, safe space to make sure that others who are going through experiences similar to mine know that they are not alone.

Emory

\* What is something you discovered about yourself in the last four years? (150 Words)

Growing up, I never liked biology. I always thought of biology as “boring” and imagined it as a field where people simply stared at forests. Taking AP Biology in my junior year completely changed my perspective. I discovered that I had a deep passion for biology. When doing the work for one of my seemingly endless class pre-discussion questions, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in biology and medicine was when I cried watching frog zygote cells divide.

At that moment, near the end of the course, I finally felt the ability to connect the dots between everything—from life to death, making sense of what I learned. There was no other subject that created that same catalyst for me. Taking the risk and exploring biology at a deeper level made me realize that I want to partake in a double major program with a Biomedical engineering degree.

OR

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I always heard my friends call each other insults, especially ones where they call each other gay. At the beginning of high school, I figured out why I was not “girl-crazy” like all the other guys I knew; I was gay. Just the word itself was one of the worst things to call someone, let alone identify as one.

I struggled with the feeling that I was inferior to others, especially when I was taught to never conform to “Western” values. Over time, with the help of my friends, teachers, and most importantly, my perseverance, I learned to accept myself while also celebrating my ethnicity and culture at the same time without having to sacrifice one or the other. In doing so, I saw myself in a place I never thought I would have been able to achieve before.

Edits: (these are both great essays so I’ll provide some feedback on both but you should decide which you submit)

Growing up, I never liked biology; I thought it was a boring field where people studied forests. However, taking AP Biology in my junior year completely changed my perspective. During one of my countless class pre-discussion questions, I saw myself unexpectedly crying while watching frog zygote cells divide. In that moment I realized that biology truly explored fundamental questions about life, sparking my deep interest in biology and medicine.

Nearing the end of the course, I finally felt able to connect the dots between everything—from life to death, making sense of what I learned. No other subject had ever catalyzed such awe for me. Taking a deeper dive into biology has made me realize that I want to pursue a Biomedical engineering degree, the intersection of biology and engineering. This discovery has influenced my academic path and ignited a passion I didn’t expect to have.

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I always heard my friends call each other insults, frequently hearing them call each other gay. At the beginning of high school, I figured out why I was not “girl-crazy” like all the other guys I knew; I was gay. Just the word itself was one of the worst things to call someone, let alone identify as one.

I struggled with the feeling that I was inferior to others, especially when I was taught to never conform to “Western” values. Over time, with the help of my perseverance, teachers, and

most importantly, surrounding myself with people who accepted me, I learned to accept myself while also celebrating my ethnicity and culture without sacrificing one for the other. In doing so, I have found myself in a place I never thought I would have been able to achieve before.

If you could be any character from an animated movie (i.e. Disney or Pixar, etc.) who would it be and why?

When I was younger, before I moved to the United States, I spent most of my day with my cousin watching Cartoon Network in Arabic. Spongebob became my role model. His unwavering enthusiasm and passion for anything he set his mind to, even when others didn't share it, inspired me to persevere through challenges, both academic and personal.

Back then, I had Spongebob shirts, Spongebob glasses, and even a Spongebob blanket. I would sometimes even imagine myself being in Spongebob's position. From working at his dream job making Krabby Patties for little pay and catching jellyfish with Patrick while also being there for Squidward without expecting anything in return, Spongebob taught me that focusing on what truly makes me happy is more important than any other factor. I would be Spongebob because I would be my true self with a friend such as Patrick that encourages me to never change.

Edits:

When I was younger, before moving to the United States, I spent much of my day watching Cartoon Network in Arabic with my cousin. Spongebob became my role model. His unwavering enthusiasm and passion for anything he set his mind to, even when others didn't share it, inspired me to persevere through challenges, both academic and personal.

Back then, I wore Spongebob shirts, and Spongebob glasses, and even owned a Spongebob blanket. Working at his dream job making Krabby Patties for little pay, and catching jellyfish with Patrick while also being there for Squidward without expecting anything in return, I envisioned myself through Spongebob. He taught me that focusing on what truly makes me happy is more important than any other factor. I would be Spongebob because I'm able to be my true self with a friend such as Patrick that encourages me to never change.

Hopkins:

Cut Down:

Saving lives through technology is my catalyst. Growing up in Egypt, I heard stories of helpless family members waiting outside of hospital rooms while technology failed to save their loved ones. Through Hopkins' Senior Fly-In Program, I plan to make my dream of developing affordable, smart technology to be utilized by underfunded hospitals a reality.

As a low-income student, I am excited to use this once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to connect with innovative leaders, such as the students who used AI to measure brain pressure and learn from their insight and knowledge. With my current resources, I used software to treat a currently incurable condition that I have, Nystagmus. Using oscillation in text, I was able to improve the vision of almost twelve individuals with Nystagmus. I hope to one day be able to use Hopkins' resources to develop even more impactful technology.

Through this program, I intend to collaborate with like-minded peers while also engaging with diverse perspectives. I'm certain that by learning about Hopkins' offerings, campus life, and student experiences, I will gain priceless insights and experiences (including making the incredibly difficult decision of choosing what to eat at the dining hall) in ways no website, video, or article could.

Haverford:

Saving lives through technology is my catalyst. Growing up in Egypt, I heard stories of helpless family members waiting outside of hospital rooms while technology failed to save their loved ones. Through Haverford and its dual degree program in collaboration with Caltech, I plan to pursue a Bachelor's in Biology and Bioengineering, making my dream of developing affordable, smart technology to be utilized by underfunded hospitals a reality.

As a low-income student, I am excited to use this once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to connect with innovative leaders and learn from their insight and knowledge. With my current resources, I used software to treat a currently incurable condition that I have, Nystagmus. Using oscillation in text, I was able to improve the vision of almost twelve individuals with Nystagmus.

I plan to use Haverford as a stepping stone to develop even more impactful technology. Through the incredible opportunities I could take advantage of, such as Haverford's Senior Research Tutorial in Bioarchitecture class, I will gain priceless insights and experiences (including choosing what to eat at the dining hall) in ways no website, video, or article could.

"The world doesn't revolve around you."

The foundations of my relationship with this person crumbled. I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but refused to continue excusing these remarks and decided to face reality.

Since discovering my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang's relationship, "my person." I yearned for someone who would willingly listen to my struggles, share my accomplishments, and incessantly talk about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for why I was the only one with an identity so condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a "sin" I didn't choose to commit, being Middle Eastern, and seen as a "good Christian man."

I had to search outside my comfort zone to find community. I put myself out there, fearing nothing. Through perseverance, trusting myself, and learning to disregard others' opinions, I learned to accept myself while celebrating my ethnicity simultaneously without having to sacrifice one or the other. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be with my biological family, with my unique experience, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with. With my experience, I hope to allow communities like mine to accept people for who they are without making them face similar struggles. Being in college will give me the space I've searched to come out and share my identity.

Amberst:

QuestBridge College Prep Scholar

Western Center Academy Honor Court (Top 20 GPAs)

Using Oscillation to Treat Nystagmus - STEM EXPO - 2x Silver Award in Riverside's Science and Engineering Fair

FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics- Significant Events/Awards: First Place: Motivate Award

Academic Decathlon-First Place: 11th, Riverside County Champions

UCLA Pre-Med Program: Most Likely to Ask Insightful Questions

I work a part-time job at a Poki place to pay for things like my gas and other essentials.

My grandmother became severely ill in the second semester of my sophomore year, leaving me as the head of the household with the responsibility of taking care of my 6-year-old sister and my other grandma.

Using Oscillation to Treat Nystagmus - STEM EXPO

Timing School: 1-5 hrs/wk

Description/Role: Working on this project for two years, using software, I was able to treat Nystagmus, an incurable condition that I have. I have entered this project two years in a row in my Science & Engineering Fair and have gotten County Silver Awards in both years. Here is the website for the project: [sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/](https://sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/)

FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics- Captain

Timing: School: 6-10 hrs/wk

Programming and maintain complex tasks and earn points

Captain, First Place: Motivate Award. Programming and maintaining the entire robot using Java to perform complex tasks and earn points and lead my team in order to foster an environment engaging peers in STEM.

Academic Decathlon

Timing: School: 11-15 hrs/wk

Participate in local, county, and state competitions, testing on seven subjects

-2024: Won National Online Champions

Coding Club - Founder

Timing: School: 1-5 hrs/wk

Collaborate with teams to create useful programs for our school, teach coding and its importance, and showcase various careers.

Volunteer at Loma Linda Hospital

Timing: 6-10 hrs/wk

Greeted and assisted patients, families, and visitors, discharged patients, and had opportunities to learn from employees.

UCLA Pre-Med Summer Program

An educational summer program for pre-med students incorporating medical guest speakers and hands-on experience.

**Q: In what ways could your unique experiences enhance our understanding of our nation and our world? (350 Words)**

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's undivided attention to make sure no similar errors occurred.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine to allow our cutting-edge technology to also be used for practical healthcare needs, as shown through my Nystagmus project. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, my goal is to create medical technology that focuses on patient safety and can better provide for their needs.

**Q: In what ways could your unique experiences enhance our understanding of our nation and our world?**

"The world doesn't revolve around you."

The foundations of my relationship with this person crumbled. I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but refused to continue excusing these comments and decided to face reality. Growing up in an Egyptian household where men's feelings are often disregarded made finding my own identity challenging.

Since realizing my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang's relationship, "my person." I yearned for someone who willingly listened to my struggles, shared the joy of my accomplishments, and talked non-stop about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for an explanation. I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like

divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn’t choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.” In my early high school years, I depended on my friends from church to accept me, so I had no choice but to accept myself too.

I had to search outside my “permitted locations” to find my community. I put myself out there, fearing nothing. Through perseverance, trusting myself, and learning to disregard others’ opinions, I learned to accept myself while also celebrating my ethnicity and culture at the same time without having to sacrifice one or the other. In doing so, I lost fear of factors outside of my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone the same way I did. No matter their biology, location, or background, no one should feel excluded from the spaces that make them who they are. Being in college will give me the space I’ve searched for to come out, and the distance from my family will allow me to create a safety net.

Bowdoin

Navigating Through Differences (250 words)

If you wish, you may share anything about the unique experiences and perspectives that you would bring with you to the Bowdoin campus and community or an experience you have had that required you to navigate across or through difference.

“The world doesn’t revolve around you.”

I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but refused to continue excusing these remarks and decided to face reality.

Since discovering my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, like Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang’s relationship, “my person.” I yearned for someone who would willingly listen to my struggles, share my accomplishments, and incessantly talk about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for why I was the only one with an identity so condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn’t choose to commit, being Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.”

I had to search outside my comfort zone to find community. I put myself out there, fearing nothing. Through perseverance, trusting myself, and learning to disregard others’ opinions, I learned to accept myself while celebrating my ethnicity without sacrificing either. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be with my biological family, with my unique experience, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with. With my experience, I hope to allow communities like mine to accept people for who they are without making them face similar struggles. Being in college will give me the space I’ve searched to come out and share my identity.

Why are you interested in participating in Explore Bowdoin? (100 words)

Saving lives through technology is my catalyst. Growing up in Egypt, I heard stories of helpless family members waiting outside of hospital rooms while technology failed to save their loved ones. Through Bowdoin, I plan to pursue a double major in Computer Science & Biology, making my dream of developing affordable, smart technology a reality.

Explore Bowdoin will allow me to learn from the diverse perspectives of professors and peers while also providing me with priceless insights and experiences (including eating at the dining hall) far beyond what any website, video, or article could.

-0FIX LAST PARAGRAPH!!

CWRU

Please indicate three extracurricular interests you would like to pursue in college.\*

While I have not met her personally, through her actions, determination, and growth, Taylor Swift is a leader who has inspired me from my childhood to the present. Throughout all of her struggles, she did not give in to the criticism and negativity. Instead, Swift was able to focus on her passion for music and channeled her focus to creating a new work of art. For example, during her conflicts with Kanye West, when an edited phone call portrayed her negatively, she chose to rise above the drama, leading to the creation of an award-winning album called *reputation*. This album, showcasing her ability to find happiness even through her lows, has gotten me through almost every stage of my life. Even through her perseverance, Swift, throughout her fame and power, has always remained humble. For example, whenever someone would compliment her, she would say "Thank you for saying that," a response that was revealed to be said since her childhood. Through not only her work but her actions and example, I have been inspired to persevere in my challenges and remain true to myself in the process.

"The world doesn't revolve around you."

I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had been said but refused to continue and decided to face reality.

Since discovering my sexuality in middle school," I yearned for someone who would willingly listen to my struggles, share my accomplishments, and incessantly talk about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for why I was the only one with an identity so condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a "sin" I didn't choose to commit, being Middle Eastern, and seen as a "good Christian man."

I had to search outside my comfort zone to find community. I put myself out there, fearing nothing. I learned to accept myself while celebrating my ethnicity without sacrificing either. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be with my biological family, with my unique experiences, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on the communities that I am apart of. Being in college will give me the space I've searched to come out and share my identity.

Colorado College (450 Words)

“The world doesn’t revolve around you.”

The foundations of my relationship with this person crumbled. I scrambled to find a way to excuse what had just been said but couldn’t; I refused to continue excusing these comments and decided to face reality. Growing up in an Egyptian household where men’s feelings are often disregarded made finding my own identity challenging. Instead of supporting the person I was becoming, my own family undermined my independence, and the struggles I faced in school and my personal life were often seen as irrelevant and unimportant compared to “my relationship with God.” These actions, however, would only fuel the fires of self-doubt, and the struggle to find my identity.

Since discovering my sexuality in middle school, I have been searching for, similar to Meredith Grey and Cristina Yang’s relationship, “my person.” I yearned for someone who would willingly listen to my struggles, share my accomplishments, and incessantly talk about life. This deep need was the consequence of my search for an explanation. I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn’t choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.” In my early high school years, I depended on my friends from church to accept me, so I had no choice but to accept myself too. Unfortunately, as with the struggles of being an unconventional person, I would have to become desensitized to whole communities rejecting me, including that one.

I had to search outside my comfort zone to find my community. In doing so, I put myself out there, fearing next to nothing. I found communities with the most diverse people I have seen, even people who are also applying to college just like me. It became a feeling like no other to know that I am *truly* not alone. With the help of my friends, teachers, and most importantly, my support, I learned to accept and depend on myself rather than others. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside of my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, no matter what college I go to, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone the same way I did. Being in college will give me the space I’ve searched for to come out, and the distance from my family will allow me to create a safety net.

## Claremont McKenna College

### 150-250 Words

At CMC, our students and faculty engage in discussion based learning. A place where civil discourse and lively debate are often at the forefront of each conversation. In what ways would your background, experiences, and values contribute to the classroom dynamic at CMC?\*

“The world doesn’t revolve around you.”

I refused to continue excusing these comments and decided to face reality. Growing up in an Egyptian household where men's feelings are often disregarded made finding my own identity challenging. These actions, however, would only fuel my resilience towards my circumstances.

Since discovering my sexuality in middle school, I questioned why, out of everyone I knew, I was the one with an identity so misunderstood and condemned. It felt like divine punishment to be bisexual, a “sin” I didn’t choose to commit, Middle Eastern, and seen as a “good Christian man.”

I had to search outside my comfort zone to find my community. In doing so, I put myself out there, fearing next to nothing. I found people who *truly* proved to me that I was not alone. I began to discover my own unique voice and perspective, no matter what community I was a part of. I learned to accept and depend on myself rather than others. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside of my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be without any contact with my biological family, at CMC, I plan to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone in their hardships. Through CMC’s SAGA organization, I hope to foster a more inclusive community using my unique perspectives and background.

At Claremont McKenna College, we believe that students should have the opportunity to apply what they learn in the classroom to real life situations. If you could work/intern anywhere in the summer, where would you like it to be? What would your role consist of? Why?\*

If I were to work anywhere, it would be with ABLE Human Motion.

Changing lives through technology drives me, influenced by my experiences growing up in Egypt. I saw technology fail to save the loved ones of many families. Seeing my grandmother’s inability to walk after a life-saving surgery emphasized the need to do better with the resources we have. ABLE Human Motion’s technology, a smart exoskeleton for disabled individuals, would allow people like my grandma to walk again without needing assistance from others.

With my passion for biology and engineering, combined with the ability to pitch ideas effectively, I would be a leader at this startup. I would be at the forefront of this life-altering technology, collaborating with patients and listening to their feedback to better serve their needs.

I would also collaborate with engineering professionals to refine and perfect this technology. My goal would be to imitate natural walking abilities as closely as possible.

Currently, I use software to treat Congenital Nystagmus, a rare and incurable condition I have that causes uncontrollable movement of the eyes. Using oscillation, I have improved the vision of nearly twelve individuals with Nystagmus. Similar to my current project, at ABLE Human Motion, I plan to create technology that accounts for the diverse disabilities of individuals no matter how rare they are.

My experiences, combined with my passion for biology and technology, would make me well-suited to lead ABLE Human Motion, driving innovation and change while leaving no one behind.

CMC Preview will connect me to like-minded peers while also allowing me to meet people with perspectives I haven't seen before. I am certain that by participating in this program and furthering my interests in biology and engineering, while also learning about everything that CMC has to offer, including financial aid and support for a transition to college, I will gain a priceless experience to truly better prepare me as a student and even a future leader.

This program's college prep workshops and in-person events will allow me to create timeless connections, learn more about campus life, the lives of the students attending, and gain priceless insights and experiences into not just college life but also experience CMC in ways no website, video, or article could.

## Pitzer

As a student who goes to a rigorous charter school with a class size of around 90, I have seen firsthand the benefits of being able to learn in a smaller environment: closer bonds with individuals and teachers, more personalized learning and help when needed, and more dedication to the students are just a few to name. Whenever I want to look into a college, I watch videos of students who go there. For Pitzer College, I watched “Why I Chose Pitzer College and What to Expect” and realized that this is a college I want to apply to because of its similar rigor and smaller class size.

From evolution to life and death, biology has the answers to nearly every aspect of nature. Similarly, technology allows for an interconnected world and an even more evolved humanity. These relatively new and complex fields allow for realities one could not have imagined even a century ago. Growing up in Egypt, I heard stories of helpless family members waiting outside of hospital rooms while medical care failed to save their loved ones. Sometimes it was as simple as a nurse or doctor forgetting to turn on a device, other times the machines were not enough to do the job. With cutting-edge technological developments, why are life-saving devices so expensive and often inadequate?

I am determined to create life-saving technology. A deep education at the intersection of biology and economics will be the first step to achieving that goal. A dual major at Pitzer would give me that opportunity. With the freedom to explore, I can study biology and economics under the tutelage of pioneers. My goals align with two of Pitzer’s core values: social responsibility to create an impact in our society and interdisciplinary learning to create innovative technology using a variety of fields.

We learn as much from our peers as from our instructors. I hope to surround myself with driven, passionate, and like-minded friends in places like Pitzer’s Robotics Club. Attending Preview Pitzer, I would have the incredible opportunity to connect with students in these clubs and learn about the paths they have forged at Pitzer College. Without these programs, I am unable to visit and experience Bates myself due to the financial burden it would impose on my family. Being able to work with diverse individuals and work towards a common goal emphasizes Pitzer’s intercultural understanding value.

I’ve always felt I’d be stuck within the boundaries of my small town, thinking my life would always remain motionless, and financial instability would be its driving force. It’s hard to move forward when in the back of your mind, you’re constantly being told there’s no way out. However, through determination, perseverance, and allowing myself to take risks, I learned that I am not contained in my current world.

Preview Pitzer will not only connect me to like-minded peers but also allow me to meet people with perspectives I haven’t seen before. It will teach me that I am not alone in my current circumstances. By participating in this program and learning about everything that Pitzer College has to offer, including the city surrounding it, campus life, and the experiences of its students, I will gain priceless insights and experiences (including eating at the dining hall) in ways no website, video, or article could.

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I had to search outside my comfort zone to find community. I put myself out there, fearing nothing. Through perseverance, trusting myself, and learning to disregard others’ opinions, I learned to accept myself while celebrating my ethnicity without sacrificing either. In doing so, I lost the fear of factors outside my control and became much more tolerant of change.

As I will officially come out and will most likely be with my biological family, with my unique experience, I will strive to ensure that I make an impact on whoever I interact with. With my experience, I hope to allow communities like mine to accept people for who they are without making them face similar struggles. Being in college will give me the space I’ve searched to come out and share my identity.

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a simple recovery except for one simple thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized for four months in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's complete and undivided attention to make sure no such simple error occurred. Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, I hope to create error-resistant technology that can not only help overwhelmed doctors but also allow them to focus on what requires their attention more

As a low-income student, I am excited to use this once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to connect with innovative leader. With my current resources, I looked for solutions to treat a currently incurable condition that I have, Nystagmus. I created a program to treat this condition. Using oscillation in text, and being allowed to gather data through my Science & Engineering Fair, I improved the vision of twelve individuals with Nystagmus. I understood the value of not just having access to resources where we can create almost anything but rather being able to utilize them to create what's never been done before.

At Dialogue with Denison, I intend to collaborate with like-minded peers while also engaging with diverse perspectives. Saving lives through technology is my catalyst. Through Denison, I plan to make my dream of developing affordable, smart technology to be utilized by underfunded hospitals a reality.

Columbia:

In addition to those already included above, please list any other STEM-related readings, activities, coursework, hobbies, research, work or other experiences and resources that have exposed you to engineering. No explanatory text or formatting is needed. (200 Words)

Being a part of FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics, in my robotics team of around seven people, I was the Lead Programmer. I went from not knowing how to make the robot move to be able to code complex programs, allow the robot to extract colors from a scene, and use machine-learning models in order to get the most points. As most of my learning was self-taught, I learned just how capable I was with resources like the internet. This journey exposed me to both the challenges involved in learning an entirely new field of engineering while also showcasing the consequences that can come after hard work and dedication.

Edits:

While I like what you wrote, I think it might be better to just list things with a brief description.

What drives you to study engineering in college? For instance, you can describe activities you have participated in that sparked your interest in engineering, explain why you want to pursue a career in engineering or share an engineering concept that you find fascinating. (200 Words) Engineering

In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology.

While doing one of my countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. No matter how much information we know about our biology, there is so much left to explore. Inspired by both fields, I knew I wanted to major in Biomedical Engineering.

Using my knowledge in both classes, I was able to enter my science fair with a solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus, using code. This program, through the use of oscillation of text, was able to improve the effects of Nystagmus on twelve individuals. To me, Biomedical Engineering is not just a major but a pathway to finding cutting-edge solutions and advancements to real-world problems.

Edits:

While doing one of my countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, my lifelong interest in medicine was sparked as I cried watching frog zygote cells divide. No matter how much information we know about our biology, there is so much left to explore.

Taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A simultaneously with the same teacher, I was able to make unexpected and unique connections between the subjects. Our teacher utilized both fields in our learning. I was taught and understood the concepts of inheritance in Java through what I had previously learned in AP Biology. These connections changed my perspective. Technology and biology didn't have to be disparate. Technology can be used to advance medicine. Motivated to be a part of these advancements, I knew I wanted to major in Biomedical Engineering.

Using my interdisciplinary perspective, I was able to enter my science fair with a solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus, using code. This program, through the use of oscillation of text, was able to improve the effects of Nystagmus on twelve individuals. To me, Biomedical Engineering is not just a major but a pathway to finding cutting-edge solutions and advancements to real-world problems.

#### What interests you about Columbia and why? (200) THIS IS COMMON TO BOTH

As a student who attends the smallest school within our community, I have seen firsthand the benefits of a close-knit learning environment. Columbia's smaller yet rigorous environment aligns perfectly with my educational values.

Living with Congenital Nystagmus showcased the immense impact of simple adjustments such as sitting closer to the board and being comfortable enough to ask instructors to read notes out loud. Columbia's commitment to personalized accommodations, combined with its small class size, reassures me that I can gain the best education while also receiving the support I need to succeed.

Columbia's unique opportunities, expertise, and connections provide a platform for innovation. Its unique location in New York—the center of trade, collaboration, and innovation—combined with its own legacy of innovation with 87 Nobel Prizes creates unparalleled opportunities. As a Biomedical Engineering major, seeing researchers at Columbia such as Azizi use AI to combat cancer, I am inspired to create medical history in the same way she did, no matter how impossible it seems.

At Columbia, I cannot wait to engage myself in a rigorous environment, collaborate with innovators, and take advantage of what New York has to offer. Columbia will provide me with the tools and support I need to create impactful innovations in medicine and beyond.

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The Engineering Preview at Columbia brings together a group of students from across the country who are curious, collaborative and excited about engineering opportunities. Tell us about an aspect of your own perspective, viewpoint or lived experience that is important to you, and how you would contribute to the EPC program? (200 Words ) Engineering

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a quick recovery except for one thing: his oxygen tank was not turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma who was hospitalized for four months in that hospital required my mom's complete and undivided attention to make sure no such errors occurred.

Witnessing the powerlessness in helping your loved ones, I hope to create error-resistant technology that can not only help overwhelmed doctors but also allow them to focus on what requires their attention more. Studying Biomedical Engineering, I am driven to ensure families never feel the same helplessness when relying on technology that is created with the sole purpose of saving lives. In a world where so many devices have become "smart," medicinal technology should be no different. That way, we can dramatically reduce preventative deaths, especially in underfunded hospitals.

At EPC, I aim to share my vision and experiences on the intersection of technology and medicine. I plan to connect with driven peers while also learning from their diverse perspectives to refine my own ideas. Through collaboration, I plan to contribute to innovations that can benefit healthcare worldwide.

Edits:

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. He would have made a quick recovery except for one thing: his oxygen tank was never turned on. Such a simple action could have saved this man's life. My grandma, who was hospitalized for four months in a neighboring hospital, required my mom's complete and undivided attention to make sure no such errors occurred.

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At EPC, I aim to share my vision and experiences with driven peers while also learning from their diverse perspectives to refine my own ideas. By collaborating with others, I plan to contribute to innovations that can create an impact on healthcare worldwide.

A hallmark of the Columbia experience is being able to learn and thrive in an equitable and inclusive community with a wide range of perspectives. Tell us about how growing up in a small town or rural community has influenced your own perspective, viewpoint or lived experience, and describe how it has shaped the way you would learn from and contribute to a diverse and collaborative campus community. (150 Words) Small Town Fly In

Being a part of my small yet rigorous community has taught me that being successful is not about location, size, or money; it's dependent on discipline, connections, and the ability to take advantage of the opportunities present, no matter how unconventional.

At my school, every teacher teaches multiple subjects, some disparate. Taking AP Biology & AP Computer Science A simultaneously, taught by the same teacher, created unpredictable connections between the two fields, inevitably sparking the creation of my Nystagmus project where I used oscillation in text to develop a treatment for a currently incurable condition, benefiting twelve individuals.

Experiences like these prove that being successful is rooted in taking advantage of the resources offered to us, no matter where we are. At Columbia, I'm eager to learn from others' diverse perspectives and explore opportunities outside of my comfort zone just as I did in my small school.

Edits:

Being a part of my suburban community has taught me that being successful is not about location, size, or money; it depends on discipline, connections, and the ability to take advantage of the opportunities present, no matter how unconventional.

At my school, every teacher teaches multiple subjects, some disparate. Taking AP Biology & AP Computer Science A simultaneously, taught by the same teacher, created unpredictable connections between the two fields, inevitably sparking the creation of my Nystagmus project where I used oscillation in text to develop a treatment for this currently incurable condition, benefiting twelve individuals.

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At Columbia, I cannot wait to engage myself in a rigorous environment, collaborate with innovators, and take advantage of what New York has to offer. Columbia will provide me with the tools and support I need to create impactful innovations in medicine and beyond.

While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore. In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unpredictable and unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biomedical Engineering. Using my knowledge in both fields, I was able to enter my science fair with a solution to an incurable eye condition that I have, Nystagmus, using software.

While there are treatments for acquired Nystagmus, that is not the case for Congenital Nystagmus. I've created a program to showcase my proposed solution. This program, through the use of oscillation of text, improved the effects of the twelve participants I had with Nystagmus. With this project, I was able to win two silver awards at my county's Science & Engineering Fair.

Here is the website link that has my entire project:

[sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/home](https://sites.google.com/stu.hemetusd.org/nystagmus/home)

Trinity:

I am an Egyptian who grew up in a traditional household. I always heard my friends call each other insults, especially ones using the word gay. At the end of my seventh-grade year, I figured out why I was not "girl crazy" like all the other guys I knew; I was gay. Back then, just the word itself was one of the worst things to call someone, let alone identify as one. I struggled with the feeling that I was "inferior" to others simply because of my sexuality, especially as someone who was raised to never conform to "Western" values. I felt as if I had to pick between my sexual orientation and my cultural identity.

Over time and perseverance, I learned to accept who I am while celebrating my culture at the same time without pulling away from one or the other. With the help of my friends, teachers, and my Middle Eastern community that shared a similar story, I not only accepted myself but also lost the fear of factors outside my control. Experiences like these allowed me to become much more tolerant of change.

As I will come out and will most likely be without any contact with my family, I would not only be involved in Trinity's Queer Resource Center but also work towards creating a more inclusive community that allows cultures like mine to accept people for who they are. No matter one's biology, identity, or background, no one should feel excluded from the spaces that make them who they are. I will strive to make an impact on whoever I interact with and ensure that they never feel alone the same way I did. Being in college will give me the space, community, and opportunity I've searched for to be myself.

Rochester

The University's mission is to **Learn, Discover, Heal, Create - and Make the World Ever Better.**

Embedded in that ideal are the values we share: **equity, leadership, integrity, openness, respect,** and **accountability.** Choose a value from the above that speaks to you and provide an example of how it guides you and your long-term goals. How are you already making your community ever better through your activism, service, or work? *This short essay is an opportunity for us to get to know you better, so specific stories are appreciated. (250 word maximum)*

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign.

Upon researching my condition, I found out that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are shown that there were also no efforts to find one.

Using the resources I had access to, I used software to create a program to treat Nystagmus. Through oscillation in text and collecting data through my Science & Engineering Fair, I was able to improve the vision of the twelve individuals with this condition. I understood the value of not just having access to resources where we can do almost anything but rather utilizing them to create what's never been done before. My experience using technology to help solve medical problems, combined with my desire for equity, paved the way for me to pursue biomedical engineering.

I am passionate about bridging the gaps between technology and medicine. Simply creating these devices, no matter how impactful they can be, is not enough; business and entrepreneurship skills are critical to driving real-world change. At Rochester, I plan to complement my engineering studies with a focus on business to create a meaningful impact.

Through equity and leadership, we can utilize our increasingly advanced, cutting-edge technology to be used for practical healthcare needs where no one is left behind.

The Multicultural Visitation Program (MVP) is designed to help prospective students get to know our diverse campus community on a more personal level. Important elements of MVP include time with a current student host and the overnight experience, free transportation to Rochester that coincides with one of our fall [Research Rochester](#) open houses, and visits to departments such as the [Office of Minority Student Affairs](#), [The David T. Kearns Center for Leadership and Diversity](#), and [the Paul J. Burgett Intercultural Center](#). Pick at least one element of the MVP program/ travel experience and share why you would like to attend MVP and how it will help in your college search. (150 words maximum)

Reading Rochester's Handbook for Underrepresented Ethnicities, I could not find an organization that represented my own—there were no Egyptian or even Middle Eastern student organizations. At MVP, I aim to connect with Middle Eastern students, learn about how these organizations are run, and gain the insight needed to create my own. My goal is to create a space where students, like me, when searching for a community that shares their identity, can find it at Rochester.

I am also an Egyptian who's both Christian and gay. Through time and perseverance, I learned to embrace my culture and identity simultaneously. At MVP, I look forward to connecting with LGBT students and communities which will provide me with a preview of the future college life I desire. I plan to explore Rochester's ELP where I can foster an inclusive community that embraces everyone's unique identities.



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Describe your career goals and aspirations. How do you plan to use your engineering degree to accomplish your goals? (1000 character limit including spaces). \*

In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on. This simple error caused an extremely preventable death. When my grandma was also hospitalized, she required my mother's undivided attention to ensure no such errors occurred. I see my family use technology that is critical to their survival. Testing their blood sugar which determines the amount of insulin they give themselves, if that technology had a bug, its effects could be truly fatal.

In a world where so many devices have become "smart," life-saving technology should be no different. I plan on developing error-resistant technology, especially for underfunded hospitals. Pursuing my EECS degree will allow me to develop smarter, yet affordable technology for individuals with disabilities, create safeguards to prevent simple errors, and innovate new technology for incurable conditions, turning my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

At Amazon, we have **16 leadership principles** that we use to drive our business. Every engineer is expected to "think big" and demonstrate "customer obsession". To demonstrate your ability to think big and have customer obsession, pick a big problem in your school or your community that you think could be solved with the help of computer science or engineering. Describe the problem, the impact it has, and describe your "think big" solution that uses engineering tools. (1000 character limit including spaces). \*

"Why do your eyes shake like that?"

This was the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes.

Upon researching my condition, I saw that the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010.

Even though me and my sister both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing the difficulty of finding a cure. Using my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. I found twelve participants and treated them through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be presented in a Science Fair. This experience drives me to continuously utilize our resources to create what's never been done before, actions that can change lives.

How has your unique identity/experience informed your desire to pursue a STEM Degree? Examples: first-generation college students, LGBTQIA, woman-identifying, first-generation in the United States, race, ethnicity, home language, financial hardship, etc. (1000 character limit including spaces).

Growing up in a traditional environment, I was torn between my sexual orientation and my racial identity.

Over time, with perseverance and tremendous support, I learned to embrace my uniqueness as a strength. My identity as a Coptic Egyptian Christian gay man is complex, but so are the successful leaders who continuously paved new and unknown paths within their fields and communities.

One should not have to pick between any part of their identity in order to find a place within their community. I strive to reinforce that within my career and the communities with which I interact. By creating new paths and publicly celebrating both of my identities, I plan to share my story and become the “first” out Egyptian to create an impact through engineering. I plan to use my STEM degree to create, advocate, and lead by example for future queer Egyptians in the process.

Tab 28

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

No matter who I was talking to, I knew this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes.

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Not only are we told that there is no cure, but we are also shown that there have been no efforts to find one. Even though my sister and I both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing even more difficulty in finding a cure.

Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. I found individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook. When they used my program, they were able to see the text as if it were still, thus improving their vision. With these results, I was able to improve the vision of my twelve participants. Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition of Nystagmus—a condition they never expected to be researched, let alone presented in a Science Fair. I saw families, ones that mirrored mine, have hope for their loved ones. I plan to utilize the concepts shown in my program towards my future goal of creating the first glasses to treat Nystagmus.

Beyond Nystagmus, I plan to use those same ambitions to develop smarter, yet affordable technology for individuals with disabilities, create safeguards to prevent simple errors, and innovate new technology for incurable conditions.. In Egypt, one of my mom's coworkers was hospitalized. However, his oxygen tank was never turned on, causing an extremely preventable death. Experiences like these also drive me to create technology to make medicine safer. I hope to use this scholarship to work towards this goal, utilizing the resources I'll have in college to continue enhancing medical technology, and ensure everyone receives the recognition and care they deserve. The Hearthstone Housing Foundation, especially with my parents' inability to financially support my higher education, will help relieve a significant burden. With this scholarship, I can focus less on financial strain and more on turning my vision of innovating technology to improve medical practices into reality.

Tab 30

Please list your most significant community service/extracurricular activities and explain your position/role in each of these activities. **(CHARACTER LIMIT: 1000)**

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No matter who I was talking to, this would be the first question asked whenever I saw someone focus on my eyes, looking at them as if they were foreign.

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010.

Using my resources, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would. I found individuals through Nystagmus support groups on platforms such as Facebook. I was able to improve twelve individuals' vision, utilizing the concepts shown in the program for my future goal of creating the first glasses to treat Nystagmus

My Nystagmus project became my most meaningful commitment as I was not only able to find a solution to a currently incurable condition but also gained foundational knowledge on research and the scientific method, including collaborating with professionals and gaining connections with other determined individuals.

I lived in Egypt for the first seven years of my life. I grew up during the Egyptian Revolution of 2011. Around two years after the revolution ended, a song called “Boshret Kheir” (Good Omen) was released. The lyrics contained the names of the major cities in Egypt, talking about the “unity of the community” and the people’s new ability to “create laws with their voice.” The music video, released a year later, depicted many citizens holding up signs either stating the name of their city or different Arabic iterations of the word “Voice.” This single song essentially became the anthem for Egyptians worldwide. It connected us and gave us an immense hope that no other song had. Without them, I wouldn’t have known about, let alone experience humanity’s biggest strengths. I saw people, including my father, fighting for justice, helping others even when it became a disadvantage for them, and uplifting their community even through their toughest battles.

Since that moment, I have not once felt unlucky to have been born with complex identities. I believe that my unique experiences and my complex identity as a queer Egyptian can be valuable for not only other Student Leaders but also others who will be inspired.

For example, seeing my peers finally feel understood when I shared my story coming out, I realized just how important connections and making others feel they belong can be.

Bank of America Student Leaders will allow me to connect with much more diverse communities outside of my own and be the pathway that will allow me to pave new paths. I will

gain a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to learn what it takes to truly create an impact from start to finish. I will learn how to support others and advocate for my beliefs, all while inspiring future Queer Egyptians to change the world for the better.

1. Choose three words that best define you and explain why you chose those words:

Energetic. Courageous. Truth.

I am a person defined by risk-taking and my inability to lie. Growing up, I was told that even if I was wrong, lying should never be part of the answer. As a result, this “skill” has allowed my peers to continuously trust me, even in times when they had to make difficult choices on which stories were truthful.

My inability to lie became the catalyst for my courage to develop. I speak out and fight for what I believe in. My courage, as a result, has given me the energy and motivation needed to consistently excel.

2. What is the best advice you have received? Why was this good advice?

“Nothing worth having comes easy.”

Academic Decathlon requires constant dedication, teamwork, and effort for our school to even have a chance at winning, especially in California, whose state champion has consistently been the national champion. Whenever our coach felt a lack of motivation, he would simply repeat this quote.

Naturally, we tend to value worth to the amount of effort required to get it. Outside of Academic Decathlon, I am constantly reminded of this advice. It has allowed me to push myself harder and achieve more than I ever thought I could, not just by motivation but consistency and dedication.

3. Pick an object in your home and describe its importance to you.

In Egypt, I remember when my parents took me to take a professional photo with them, being too scared to stand on what seemed to be a “bowl.” As a result, they lifted me while continuously making it look like I was still standing.

A tall photograph in a brown picture frame depicts this memory as a unique reminder. This object, which has remained on my desk throughout my life, resembles my upbringing, the values I was raised with, and an almost unlimited motivation to fight for the parents who changed their entire lives to allow me to be here.

4. Why should you be the next Aspiring Scholar?

When I shared my story of growing up as a queer Egyptian, I saw the peers with whom I connected during my college application journey finally feeling understood. My story was shockingly similar to the peers who read it.

My unique experiences can not only be valuable to other Aspiring Scholars but for future Egyptians who can be inspired by examples of the leaders with whom they could see themselves in. I want to be the person who creates an impact where people no longer have to be the “first” of their identity to be leaders.

### **Themed Questions (150-300 words, 2000 character limit)**

Please choose **any two** of the seven following prompts to answer. All prompts are given equal weight.

**1.** All of a sudden, you're given a budget of \$5,000,000 and have been thrown into the executive position of a nonprofit. What field does your nonprofit target, why that field, and **how will you lead your team** to invoke the changes you want to see?

If I had \$5,000,000 to start a nonprofit, I would create an initiative that focuses on treating and even curing rare conditions. I know the struggle of not only being told there is no cure for my condition, but that there is also little effort in finding a treatment. My nonprofit would not only use this budget to fund research for rare conditions and biological problems but also ensure that they are acknowledged, consistently researched, and given the same priority as more common ones. I would do everything in my power to transform people's lives, no matter how rare, for the better.

As captain of my FTC Robotics team, what consistently motivates my team is finding their passion and utilizing it throughout every task. Whenever I delegate tasks, I dedicate them to individuals who I know will not only succeed but enjoy working on the task. I will lead my team by understanding what drives them. Whether it's a family member or a friend who was simply not given the same attention due to the “rarity” of their case, I would attempt to understand their main goals. We will focus on one condition at a time, allowing an entire team to dedicate their attention to solving the impossible. Because of their own unique experiences, they can also offer unique ideas, feedback, and even solutions.

If money will not be an issue, I would also ensure that everyone can access these treatments no matter their financial status or where they live. As a result, with constant teamwork, dedication, and the funding I will have access to, I plan to create a new field of medicine that doesn't focus on the majority but rather on rare, unique cases of individuals who have become someone father, sister, son, etc. who can truly benefit from even knowing that their issues are acknowledged and researched.

I lived in Egypt for the first seven years of my life. I grew up during the Egyptian Revolution of 2011. Around two years after the revolution ended, a song called “Boshret Kheir” (Good Omen) was released. The lyrics contained the names of the major cities in Egypt, talking about the “unity of the community” and the people’s new ability to “create laws from their voice.” The music video, released a year later, depicted many citizens holding up signs either stating the name of their city or different Arabic iterations of the word “Voice.”

This single song essentially became the anthem for Egyptians worldwide. It connected us and gave us an immense hope that no other song had. It connected us and gave us an immense hope that no other song had. Without them, I wouldn’t have known about, let alone experience humanity’s biggest strengths. I saw people, including my father, fighting for justice, helping others even when it became a disadvantage for them, and uplifting their community even through their toughest battles.

Being a leader means taking risks, especially when the outcome is unknown. Leading means creating an impact no matter how small. Leadership isn’t about who has the most control or who leads statistically but rather creating a difference, even if it's an individual. Thus, by these qualities, leadership encompasses everyone who was involved in this movement. From the person holding a sign to Hussain Al Jassmi, the creator of this song, every individual involved was crucial for this change to occur. No matter what career, leadership requires a vision, confidence, and courage to continuously persevere through unavoidable obstacles. While it may be difficult, experiencing the results and its priceless impact on the communities around us makes it truly worth it.

**4.** Being a film director is a lot like leading a project for movies! Choose a subject to direct a film/documentary around, and **why** you should **lead** this project over other directors in the business.

Most films today portray straight families that might either work through conflicts together or within their family or are simply happy, unproblematic, and supportive. Growing up, it was difficult to relate to either style of entertainment. My family and I would remain extremely close as long as I remained straight. Little to no films are entered around not simply coming out to an unsupportive family but continuously working through issues like these. That

was until I watched *Love, Victor*, a show that showcases a teen's journey through discovering, coming out, working through challenges, and fulfilling a life that is true to oneself.

I saw myself through Victor's actions. Before I accepted my sexuality, I forced myself to create fake crushes. It was as if every time I could manufacture feelings I would feel relieved as I wouldn't have to worry about coming out.

I plan to create a film that showcases my unique yet relatable story in an effort to humanize one of our most controversial issues today. Growing up as the "most active" person in the church, hiding who I was for years, and having worked through countless hypotheticals, I have experienced and persevered through obstacles that simply had no true solution.

Victor's ability to not only come out to his parents but actively fight for his identity through countless adversities, some of which were similar to mine, has motivated me to come out for the first time after three years of hiding it. A single story can truly change a life.

I should lead this project to not only be that story that future generations can look up to and use as their motivation to come out but also create uncomfortable yet crucial dialogue and change within every community that sees it. I hope that my film can be the catalyst for many more films that follow it.

*Love, Victor* taught me that what may seem as essentially the end of the world could also be the moment that, over time, can cause life to change for the better. I learned that change, especially when it comes to coming out to a family that might see it as the worst thing for their child to be, is usually not quick or easy. However, no matter the results of these reactions and challenges, it will always be worth it if it results in truly embracing who you are. Victor's story, combined with the unparalleled experience of being publicly out, has not only motivated me to come out to my family when it's safe to do so but also, in college and beyond, ensure that anyone who is going through similar circumstances knows that they are not alone.

Horatio Alger

**The Horatio Alger Association was founded to promote the belief that greatness can be achieved in America regardless of one's circumstances or background. This concept is referred to as the American Dream.**

**Provide your response to both of the following:**

- 1. What is your personal view of the American Dream?**
- 2. How do you intend to pursue your American Dream? \***

“Secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity.” This right is woven into the fabric of our American society.

My American dream involves this right. My dream is not simply to live in a liberated society but to consistently fight to improve it in whatever way possible. My dream involves creating an environment where innovation is encouraged with no strings attached.

I believe that my path to achieving that dream is through medicine. Seeing families in Egypt endure deaths from preventable causes due to lack of funding and resources has motivated me to pursue a Biomedical Engineering degree, paving my dream of creating smarter and more innovative technology that can be utilized to help both our nation and the Earth we share. As a result, no matter one's circumstances or background, they can be given more equitable care, saving both a life and a dream in the process.

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EC

**Founder, Using Oscillation to Treat Nystagmus – STEM EXPO**

Computer/Technology

Grades: 10, 11, 12

3 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr

I wrote software to treat Congenital Nystagmus, a currently incurable condition, and improved the vision of 12 individuals. (2x Silver Award at RCSEF)

**Captain, FIRST Tech Challenge Robotics**

Computer/Technology

Grades: 11, 12

8 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr

Led team through STEM outreach (K-12) and programming strategic robots to earn the most points.

**Member, Academic Decathlon**

Grades: 11, 12

15 hr/wk, 35 wk/yr

Participated in competitions where I learned and tested on seven subjects.

**Founder, Technology Club**

Grades: 11, 12

2 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr

Collaborated with members to learn about engineering, showcased and motivated students for future technological careers.

**Volunteer, Loma Linda Medical Center Murrieta**

Grades: 11, 12

8 hr/wk, 35 wk/yr

Greeted and assisted families and visitors. Discharged patients, maintained cleanliness, and learned from the medical professionals I worked with.

**Participant, UCLA Pre-Med Summer Program**

Grade: 11 (Break)

30 hr/wk, 1 wk/yr

An educational summer program for pre-med students, incorporating medical guest speakers and hands-on experience. I held a human brain and heart!

**Family Responsibilities, My House**

Grades: 9, 10, 11, 12

3 hr/wk, 35 wk/yr

I help with translating, educating my sister, taking care of my grandmother, and cleaning around the household.

**Work (Paid), Poki Poki Temecula**

Grades: 11, 12

4 hr/wk, 20 wk/yr

Served 200-300 people per day. Created customized poké bowls. Maintained cleanliness and organization.

**Member, National Honor Society**

Grades: 10, 11, 12

3 hr/wk, 35 wk/yr

Participated in STEM outreach in elementary schools. Created posters and stickers to encourage students to pursue STEM. NHS Service Award.

**Participant, Hemet Mayor Mentee Program**

Grade: 11

3 hr/wk, 16 wk/yr

Learned how our city was governed, developed policy recommendations, picked courses of action, and became fully engaged within my community.

From evolution to life and death, biology has the answers to nearly every aspect of nature. Similarly, STEM allows for an interconnected world and an even more evolved humanity. While doing another one of my almost countless pre-discussion questions for AP Biology, the moment that sparked my lifelong interest in medicine was when I cried seeing frog zygote cells divide. The fact that we and our environment originated from a single-cell dividing made biology a field like no other. No matter how much information we currently know about our biology, it felt like there was so much more to explore.

In taking AP Biology and AP Computer Science A at the same time, taught by the same teacher, I was able to make unique connections between the two subjects, inevitably sparking my interest in engineering as well. For example, our teacher taught us about inheritance in Java using concepts we learned in AP Biology. Utilizing both of these subjects, I knew that I wanted to major in Biological Engineering. Attending the UCLA Pre-Med summer scholars program, I was able to hold a real human brain and heart in my own hands, a truly surreal experience. Biological Engineering became not just a major but a pathway to finding cutting-edge solutions and skills in almost any career. I don't want to just see change, I want to be it.

HackMIT

Tell us about your background. Have you coded before, or do you have other skills that you hope to use during the hackathon weekend? [900 chars] \*

As a student who went to a small school, being a part of clubs like FTC Robotics requires taking on multiple roles. Initially starting as Lead Programmer, I didn't know how to make the robot move. However, over time, I was able to create programs like one that utilizes sensors and creates movement depending on where an object is.

Taking AP Computer Science A and using that same language on Android Studio for FTC, my background in coding mainly involves Java. I learned not only how and when to create, use (and of course, reuse) code, but also how to deal with multiple files and debugging. FTC taught me not just how to code but find and create efficient solutions.

Beyond FTC, I have a background in Python, JavaScript, HTML, and CSS. I hope to expand my knowledge of these languages at DivHacks to be able to create even more impact. Likewise, I have a passion for writing and documenting both my stories and perspectives, and am excited to continue developing this skill. DivHacks will provide me with a priceless, unique opportunity to connect with others, develop interdisciplinary skills, and grow during the start of my college career.

Write about a time when you worked in a team. What were your strengths and weaknesses? What role did you play? [900 chars] \*

During my senior year, I became captain of my FTC Robotics team. It was hard to find a "golden ratio" between letting everyone do their thing to simply directing others. As my school is 6th-12th grade, most of my team members were younger. My biggest weakness was getting everyone to focus on their tasks at hand. However, over time, I learned that getting my team to focus wasn't about being more strict. It was understanding what consistently motivated my team.

Over time, I directed their focus to finding their passion and utilizing it throughout every task. I delegated tasks to individuals whom I know will both succeed and enjoy working on the task. I led my team by understanding what drives them. I emphasized the need for collaboration by consistently checking up, helping, and separating difficult objectives into smaller, more manageable ones, resulting in both success and passion.

What draws you to hackathons, and how do you hope HackMIT will help you grow? [900 chars] \*

What HackMIT and MIT have in common is the critical need for collaboration. As a pre-fresh MIT student who is currently in Interphase, I have seen the way collaboration can drastically benefit everyone involved. Assignments like PSETS would take multiple times longer to complete if collaboration were not allowed.

At HackMIT, I plan to bring this mindset into "doing the impossible. I'm excited to network with, learn from, and work with unique individuals from all around the world. HackMIT will allow me to both develop and utilize my technical knowledge to create an impact like never before. I can't wait to bring ideas into life, innovate, and create solutions that can improve the lives of others.

HackMIT will help me grow much more beyond my technical skills. It will create priceless connections, experiences, and inspiration that will illuminate and become a part of my path at MIT.

Share a project that you're proud of, technical or non-technical! [900 chars] \*

"Why do your eyes shake like that?"

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010. Even though my sister and I both have Congenital Nystagmus, its effects are different, emphasizing the difficulty in finding a cure.

Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus. When individuals from support groups on platforms such as Facebook used my program, they were able to see the text as if it were still. I was able to improve the vision of the twelve participants in my project.

Although I thought my condition was considered extremely rare, presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, grateful for the recognition. I saw families, ones that mirrored mine, have hope for their loved ones.

These results reflect my goal of creating the first glasses to treat Nystagmus. Experiences like these drive me to continue acknowledging medical minorities, utilize the resources I'll have in college to continue advancing medicine through technology, and ensure everyone receives the recognition and care they deserve.

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

Congenital Nystagmus affects each person differently, emphasizing the difficulty in finding a cure.

Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program that would oscillate text at the same speed as someone's eyes would, calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus.. I was able to improve the vision of the twelve participants in my project.

These results reflect my goal of creating the first glasses to treat Nystagmus. Experiences like these drive me to continue advancing medicine through technology, and ensure everyone receives the recognition and care they deserve.

# Columbia Hacks

What excites you about participating in DivHacks 2025? In what ways are you hoping this experience will challenge or develop your current abilities? (200 words max)

What DivHacks and Columbia have in common is the critical need for collaboration. As a pre-frosh MIT student who took part in summer courses, I have seen the way collaboration can drastically benefit everyone involved. Assignments like PSETS would take multiple times longer to complete if collaboration were not allowed.

I plan to bring this mindset into DivHacks. I'm excited to grow in new environments where I can network with, learn from, and work with unique individuals from all around the world. Alongside our competitive drive that allows us to become our best, I'm excited to meet people who have similar burning passions but with their own vision of a better society. DivHacks will allow me to strengthen both my technical skills and creativity. I can't wait to bring my ideas and skills to life, innovate, and create real solutions that can improve the lives of others.

DivHacks is a reflection of real-world spaces, where teamwork, challenging competition, and creativity are not only present but critical to developing the best solutions. DivHacks will create priceless connections, experiences, and thus, inspiration that will illuminate and become a part of my path that I will carry with me at MIT and beyond.

I'm excited to grow in new environments where I can network with, learn from, and work with unique individuals from all around the world. Alongside our competitive drive that allows us to become our best, I'm excited to meet people with their own vision of a better society. StarkHacks will allow me to strengthen both my technical skills and creativity. I can't wait to bring my ideas and skills to life, innovate, and create real solutions that can improve the lives of others.

StarkHacks is a reflection of real-world spaces, where teamwork, challenging competition, and creativity are not only present but critical to developing the best solutions.

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Harvard

What excites you about participating in DivHacks 2025? In what ways are you hoping this experience will challenge or develop your current abilities? (200 words max)

What Harvard and MIT have in common is the critical need for collaboration. MIT Assignments like PSETs would take multiple times longer to complete if collaboration were not allowed.

I plan to bring this mindset into HackHarvard. I'm excited to grow in reflection of real-world spaces, where teamwork, challenging competition, and creativity are not only present but critical to developing the best solutions. I am excited to acquire skills in relation to machine learning with other skilled peers.

If I had unlimited resources, I would start a business that cures rare conditions. Living with Nystagmus, I know the struggle of not only being told there is no cure, but that there is also little effort in finding one. I would also ensure that every condition is taken care of. I would do everything in my power to transform people's lives, including my own, for the better. Furthermore, everyone can access these treatments, no matter their financial status or where they live.

“Why do your eyes shake like that?”

Upon researching my condition, I saw the last clinical trial done on Congenital Nystagmus was in 2010.

Using the resources I had, such as my computer, I created a program calibrated for each person's unique Nystagmus, improving the vision of the twelve participants in my program.

Presenting my project felt transformative as families approached me, shocked by this recognition— a condition they never expected to be presented in a Science Fair.